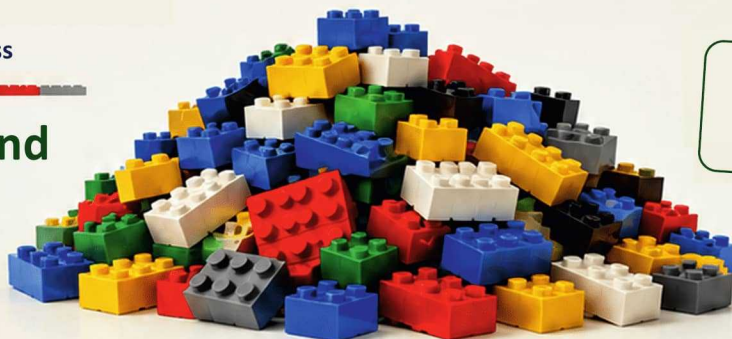


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NRIs: Living abroad doesn't put you beyond taxman's radar
P8



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Factor indices

2026 rewards Alpha, leaves defensives behind

Welcome to TrendMap, your guide to the performance of different investment segments. In this edition, we present a 10-year performance tracker of various factor-based investment strategies. The annual returns are ranked for 6 key NSE Factor indices, with a broad-based index, Nifty 500, thrown in for comparison. This map shows that no single-factor strategy consistently outperforms, making a strong case for diversification. By **Sameer Bhardwaj**.

How precious metals shone

Gold (995) (₹) price of 10 g	Silver (₹) price of 1 kg
1,45,758 3 July 2026	2,33,858 3 July 2026
96,947 3 July 2025	1,07,620 3 July 2025

Source: IBJA



THE ECONOMIC TIMES
wealth



Rank	2017	2018	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026*	10-year return
1	Alpha 57.5%	Quality 7.5%	Alpha 10.4%	Quality 24.3%	Alpha 53.5%	Value 19.1%	Value 58.3%	Alpha 26.0%	Value 18.3%	Alpha 4.6%	Alpha 18.9%
2	Momentum 52.9%	Low Volatility 6.3%	Momentum 9.8%	Alpha 22.5%	Momentum 51.1%	Nifty 500 1.6%	Alpha 55.6%	Value 20.2%	Low Volatility 9.8%	Value 2.1%	Momentum 16.7%
3	Nifty 500 35.5%	Momentum -1.9%	Nifty 500 7.3%	Low Volatility 21.6%	Value 41.6%	Equal Weight -0.1%	Momentum 40.2%	Momentum 19.6%	Equal Weight 8.0%	Equal Weight 0.1%	Value 16.1%
4	Equal Weight 33.0%	Nifty 500 -2.8%	Quality 4.0%	Momentum 18.9%	Equal Weight 31.4%	Low Volatility -0.6%	Low Volatility 30.5%	Equal Weight 16.3%	Nifty 500 6.2%	Momentum -1.3%	Nifty 500 12.7%
5	Value 29.1%	Alpha -8.3%	Low Volatility 3.7%	Nifty 500 16.5%	Nifty 500 29.6%	Quality -7.1%	Quality 30.2%	Nifty 500 14.9%	Quality 2.8%	Nifty 500 -3.8%	Equal Weight 12.4%
6	Low Volatility 27.7%	Equal Weight -9.5%	Equal Weight 2.0%	Equal Weight 16.0%	Quality 23.1%	Momentum -7.5%	Equal Weight 29.3%	Quality 12.4%	Momentum -5.4%	Low Volatility -6.7%	Low Volatility 11.5%
7	Quality 27.6%	Value -21.2%	Value -11.2%	Value 1.2%	Low Volatility 21.1%	Alpha -11.2%	Nifty 500 25.2%	Low Volatility 11.0%	Alpha -5.8%	Quality -8.4%	Quality 10.5%

Alpha investing pays off over the long run

Investors in 2026 have leaned towards Valuation-driven and Alpha-oriented strategies. The Alpha factor has been the standout performer, with stocks that delivered strong historical excess returns continuing to outperform despite volatile markets. The Value strategy has also held up well, as investors increasingly favoured fundamentally inexpensive companies.

The Equal Weight index has remained

broadly flat, indicating more dispersed returns, with several smaller constituents either holding steady or generating gains. In contrast, the Nifty 500 has declined 3.8%, reflecting broader market weakness.

On the other hand, Quality and Low Volatility factors have underperformed. Traditionally seen as defensive plays during uncertain periods, these strategies have faced a reversal in investor preference this

year. Valuation compression has weighed on Quality strategy, while reduced interest in defensive sectors such as consumer staples and utilities has dragged down the performance of Low Volatility strategy.

Long-term performance

Over the past decade, the Alpha factor has emerged as the clear standout, underscoring the effectiveness of strategies

focused on identifying stocks capable of consistently outperforming the broader market. Momentum has been the next best performer, highlighting how investing in stocks with strong price trends has created substantial wealth over time. The Value factor, too, has delivered robust compounded returns, benefiting from periodic market rotations into attractively valued stocks.

THE ECONOMIC TIMES

wealth

IS YOUR HOME LOAN RULING YOUR LIFE?

The biggest cost of a home loan isn't the EMI, but the freedom it takes away. **P2**

+

**NRIs: LIVING ABROAD
DOESN'T PUT YOU BEYOND
TAXMAN'S RADAR **P08****

**FOREIGN UNIVERSITIES
ARE HERE, AND CHEAPER.
SHOULD YOU ENRÔL? **P12****



The home loan trap

Is it ruling your life?

The real burden of a big home loan is not the EMI alone, but the flexibility it takes away and the control it exerts over your life.



Kiran Chowdhury, 49

- Systems transformation leader**
- At age 33, poured life savings into downpayment for a house
- Initial EMI outflow came at a stiff 60% of his income
- Additional top-up loans followed for house upgrades and other expenses
- EMI burden did not permit a comfortable lifestyle
- Didn't allow for spends on travel and vacations
- EMIs left shortfall in savings, putting a lid on corpus accumulated

by Sanket Dhanorkar

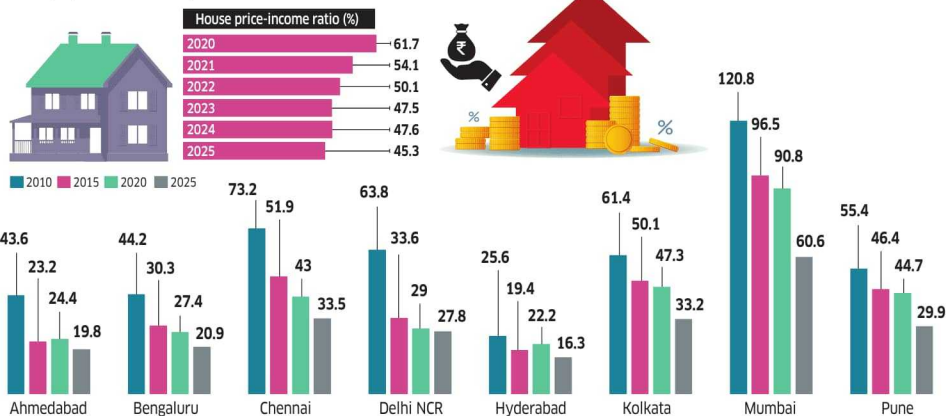
Emotions led Mumbai-based Sharon Alwyn Sequeira, now 44, to purchase a ₹22 lakh house in 2008. His wife was about to have their first child. A house to call their own felt right at the time. He took a home loan, locking him into equated monthly instalments (EMI) of ₹19,000—not a paltry sum, considering his then-monthly salary of ₹25,000. Little did he know how the home loan would push him to years of uncomfortable choices.

Initial years were spent living paycheck to paycheck. They borrowed from close family to tide over shortfalls. A top-up loan followed, pushing up EMI outgo to ₹30,000. To afford their lifestyle, Sequeira began putting in the grind at work—constantly pushing himself in pursuit of bonuses, increments and promotions. Regular night shifts took away precious moments with the family.

By 2013, his income had doubled, but EMIs continued to weigh heavily. A second child was on the way. A stint abroad followed; the whole family

Home affordability has steadily improved, says the math

While average housing affordability, measured by the price-to-income ratio, has improved across cities, these calculations overlook the hidden lifestyle, career and family trade-offs of a home loan.



Source: Colliers India. Note: Average housing prices are calculated basis the composite carpet prices for 50 cities in India and assumed for a 1,000 sq ft unit | Average income is per-capita disposable income per annum.

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moved, but the high cost of living offset the benefits of the bigger paycheck. The relentless climb up the corporate ladder continued. He finally closed the home loan in 2019, but not after a stressful journey that took a toll on family and professional life. "The EMI burden pushed my family into a constrained lifestyle. I constantly felt the need to grow professionally. The stress of not losing my job and not compromising on work seeped into my everyday behaviour," he laments.

Big loan, bigger trade-offs

Sequeira's tale is one many home loan borrowers live. For Indians, buying a home is not only about math. It is a decision laced with emotions, rooted in a deep cultural sense of security and self-worth. This sentiment makes us stretch our finances thin and pledge two, even three decades' worth of future income to fund that dream home.

But a home loan commitment is rigid and unforgiving. It demands fealty even when personal circumstances get shaky. It doesn't just leave a mark on our finances. It surreptitiously anchors critical aspects of our life—shaping lifestyle choices, career paths, shared family experiences and even our own behaviour. Home affordability calculations do not account for such detours.

Deferred savings, investments

A running home loan has occupied a big share of Kiran Chowdhury's household expenses for the last 16 years. At 33, the Mumbai resident had poured a chunk of his savings into the down-payment for a house in Mumbai's suburbs. The initial EMI outflow came at a stiff 60% of his income. Soon, he opted for another house in a bigger complex. A sizeable shortfall, even after selling the earlier home, meant his loan burden persisted. Additional top-up loans funded house upgrades and other expenses.

As the sole earning member in a family comprising his spouse, two kids, and parents, he found that the rigid monthly EMI payments did not permit a comfortable lifestyle for most of his prime working years. Now, with a better income profile, Chowdhury has more breathing room—the ongoing EMIs shave off less than 20% of his income. But navigating the multi-year loan has left his family starving in two areas of their lives. One, it simply didn't allow for spending on travel and vacations. The family couldn't create enough memories together. Two, the EMIs left a big shortfall in their savings. "I could not build adequate corpus at this stage of my life," he rues.

For many, juggling a hefty home loan EMI feels like it overwhelms everything else. Savings and investments often fall prey first. Adhil Shetty, CEO, BankBazaar, points out, "One of the biggest trade-offs is between servicing the loan and pursuing other financial goals. Higher EMIs can reduce the ability to build an emergency fund, invest for retirement or create long-term wealth." According to Ritesh Srivastava, Founder & CEO, FREED, a debt relief platform, deferring savings and investments is the most damaging because it is invisible. "Money meant for retirement, an emergency fund, or insurance is pushed to the 'once the loan is lighter' phase of life, which costs people the exact years compounding works

Indians are taking bigger home loans

75 lakh+ ticket size segment continues to grow, accounting for 40% of the originations value.

Ticket size wise originations share of home loans (%)

Period	<5 lakh	5-25 lakh	35-75 lakh	>75 lakh
Oct-Dec 2024	1.2	33.7	30	35.1
Jan-Mar 2025	1.3	32.7	29.5	36.6
Apr-Jun 2025	1.3	32	29.5	37.2
Jul-Sep 2025	1.3	30.8	29.3	38.5
Oct-Dec 2025	1.1	29.9	29.3	39.7

Source: CRIF High Mark report 'How India Lends'



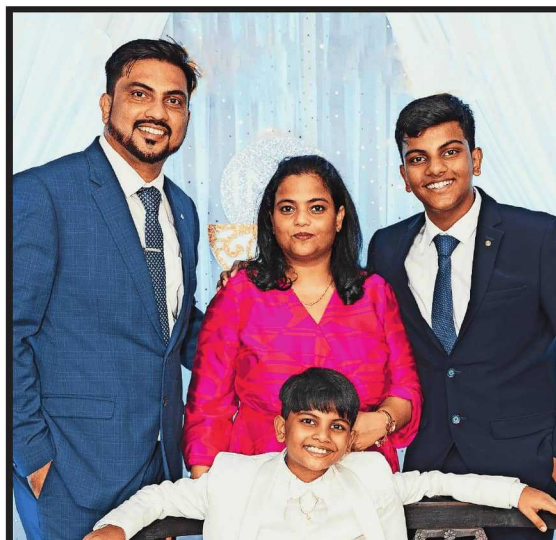
A home loan commitment is rigid and unforgiving. It demands fealty even when personal circumstances get shaky.

hardest." A home loan makes great sense on top of a healthy savings habit, not in place of one, he adds.

When the EMI squeeze really bites, existing investments often become the first line of defence. Mangesh Zope, Founder of Peaceful Loans, a loan consultancy for borrowers, has seen many instances of this. "Sometimes, in an emergency, you might even have to liquidate a couple of investments which you didn't want to." Likewise, to tide over the liquidity crunch, some homebuyers may be forced to take more unsecured loans to meet their expenses and family aspirations, points out Mrin Agarwal, Founder, Finsafe India. This can spell disaster for other important milestones in your life.

Cutting corners

Lifestyle compression is another casualty of inflated EMIs. Nisreen Mamaji, Founder, MoneyWorks Financial Services, asserts, "People cut back on the things that actually



Sharon Alwyn Sequeira, 44

Client operations manager

Bought a house in 2008 at age 26 when wife was about to have first child

Home loan EMI of ₹19,000 weighed heavy on then monthly salary of ₹25,000

Initial years spent living paycheck to paycheck

Top-up loan added to burden, family lived constrained lifestyle



Forced to push himself at work in pursuit of promotions, increments



Didn't pursue opportunities outside his job; chose comfort over risk

matter (eating out, travel, learning) to make room for a mortgage payment. Over 20 years, that's a quality-of-life trade-off nobody really prices in." Both Sequeira and Chowdhury count forgone travel among the biggest trade-offs in their home loan pursuits.

Bengaluru resident Rustam Sandhu, 37, overshot his budget by 50% when he bought a 4-BHK house earlier this year. He has opted for an under-construction property, with possession scheduled for the end of this year (2026). His home loan meter started running last month. The father of two kids, ages 2 and 4, is currently shelling out both rent and EMIs. The latter will chew into 35% of his income.

To his credit, he has mapped out his loan repayment journey for the next few years. He has put aside 6-8 months' worth of running expenses. He maintains that he has worked on multiple expense scenarios that will allow him to manage both rent and EMI outgo, while still saving at least ₹1 lakh a month.

But Sandhu's calculations involve some downsizing of household budgets. He has drawn a red line on certain spends. Parties and eating out will be severely curtailed. International vacations are ruled out.

Monthly subscriptions to OTT channels have been ruthlessly pruned. Even groceries have been partially scaled down from premium brands in certain categories. Sandhu admits, "The EMI calculus seems comfortable on paper, but the tricky part starts when both EMI and household expenses start running in tandem."

Life, interrupted

The lingering effects of a big home loan EMI aren't just limited to cramped budgets and squeezed savings. A large EMI can also quietly shape decisions beyond personal finance, points out Shetty of BankBazaar. "Borrowers may become more cautious about changing jobs, relocating, taking career breaks or starting a business," he remarks.

The home loan quietly constricts your options. Mamaji observes that people take fewer calculated risks (staying in mediocre jobs, avoiding entrepreneurship, turning down sabbaticals) because they can't afford 2-3 months without salary. "A ₹50 lakh EMI means you're locked into paycheck stability, even when a job



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change or skill-building break could accelerate your career."

Until a few months ago, Mumbai-based Ninad Pathak, 32, worked as a freelance writer with a relaxed work schedule. With his wife expecting soon, he recently bought a ₹1 crore house on loan. The constant monthly EMI of ₹55,000 did not sit well with an erratic income profile. His wife may also not resume work after maternity. So he went from freelancing to taking up a full-time job. Despite a resulting sharp drop in income, Pathak finds greater comfort in the stability of his permanent job. Adjusting to the new way of life has been difficult, with family and personal time traded for income security. Pathak, who also cut ongoing systematic investment plans (SIPs) to afford the EMI, wants to pay off the home loan early so it doesn't burden the family for longer.

Sequeira rues how his own career could have benefited if he hadn't chosen comfort over risk. When opportunities arose outside his prevailing job, he chose the known confines of his existing environment. He didn't risk switching, even when his career could have benefited from the move. As Srivastava of FREED avers, "People stay in roles they have outgrown, or pass up a better but riskier move, because a high EMI leaves no room for an income gap."

Sometimes, a bloated EMI also casts its shadow over the borrower's family. Even a life decision like family planning gets viewed through the lens of the ongoing EMI. A second child becomes a "can we afford the EMI still?" question, not a personal one. School fees and even childcare decisions are held hostage by the home loan, points out Mamaji.

Rethinking affordability

Homeownership remains a major priority for many. The aspirations keep growing, and so do the home loan ticket sizes. According to CRIF High Mark, a credit bureau, the value share of loans exceeding ₹75 lakh in originations jumped to 40% in the year-ago period. But the bigger the loan, the longer the shadow it casts on your life. As Mamaji of MoneyWorks Financial Services says, the home loan often becomes the "invisible choreographer of major life decisions."

This isn't to say that a home loan is bad. When taken thoughtfully, it is the cheapest credit you can access to build a lifelong asset. But it becomes a problem when it plays the puppet-master in your life. Srivastava asserts, "A home loan is rarely the problem. An oversized EMI with no savings cushion behind it is. The day your loan starts dictating your career, your family decisions, and your sleep, it has stopped being an asset and started running your life."

What seems affordable today may not prove so after a few years. Often, homebuyers build in rosy assump-

Don't be fooled by lower EMIs

Lesser EMI burden may tempt you to opt for borrowing more or stretching tenure.

Loan amount (₹)	Loan tenure			
	15 years	20 years	25 years	30 years
50 lakh	47,783	41,822	38,591	36,688
1 crore	95,565	83,644	77,182	73,376
2 crore	1,91,130	1,67,288	1,54,363	1,46,753

A 25-30 year tenure may make EMI burden lighter, but stretch your obligation and reduce margin for error. Source: SBI

Beyond the math: your real home loan affordability test

Your home loan EMI is not really comfortable if it:

- Makes you downsize household budgets and cut corners
- Forces you to stay in a job you have outgrown
- Makes you pass up a better but riskier career move or take a career break
- Makes you averse to relocation or start a business
- Leaves no financial cushion in case of a medical emergency or caregiving duties
- Forces you to defer savings or liquidate investments
- Limits your flexibility in family planning
- Puts stress on daily living (commute time, quality of life etc)

The real test of a home loan is not whether the EMI looks affordable today, but whether it lets you absorb life's many vagaries.

tions of how their income will grow over the years. This hallucination forms the basis for committing to a high-value loan, even when current circumstances do not favour such an outflow. Perhaps at the outset you can even afford to pay off the high EMIs. But then life happens.

What if one partner is left jobless for an extended period of time? This is a reality

only works when everything goes right, it is too big.

The real test of a home loan is not whether the EMI looks affordable today, but whether it lets you absorb life's many vagaries, Shetty exhorts. "One of the biggest mistakes homebuyers make is assuming that the maximum loan they qualify for is the amount they should borrow. In reality, affordability should account for future uncertainties such as job changes, medical emergencies, career breaks and evolving family responsibilities." Mamaji avers, "A home loan shouldn't be sized by what the bank will give you—it should be sized by

what your life can handle. That's a very different conversation."

Banks assess your eligibility, not your life, and that gap is where regret is born, cautions Srivastava. "Most lenders will sanction EMIs of up to 45 to 50% of income, but once you are living at that ceiling for 20 years, the loan stops being a line item and quietly becomes a partner in every big decision that follows." The question is never whether to take one; it is how well it sits alongside the rest of your financial life, he adds.

Now debt-free, Sequeira feels the weight off his shoulders. His family now moves freely, travels, explores places and cuisines. Looking back, he says, "I should not have rushed into buying a house. It was a purely emotional decision that put me on a long, painful journey of crippling insecurity." Chowdhury, whose ongoing loan no longer has a grip on his life, maintains, "EMI should not be over 30-35% of your monthly income. Anything beyond this puts a lot of pressure on other critical areas of your life."

Homes must be purchased based on affordability and not on aspirations, Agarwal of Finsafe insists. Don't buy bigger space than you need. Buy for today's needs. Try to optimise the loan down payment such that it doesn't squeeze immediate liquidity, while ensuring loan amount, and therefore EMI outgo, is minimised. Factor in ancillary costs, including stamp duty, society maintenance charges, property taxes and interior expenses, exhorts Zope of Peaceful Loans. Be mindful of how the choice of locality and housing project can shape your lifestyle expenses.

Beyond finances, softer factors matter too, says Shetty. "Commute time, quality of life, proximity to schools and healthcare, and future family needs can significantly shape daily living. The right home loan should enable homeownership without compromising your future financial flexibility."

Your dream home should give you the freedom to flourish, not constrain your choices. Size the purchase so it doesn't become a noose around your neck.



Ninad Pathak, 32

Full-time writer

Recently bought a ₹1 crore house on loan



Income has dropped sharply, and adjusting to new work life has been difficult

Monthly EMI did not sit well with erratic income profile as freelancer



Had to take up full-time job, finding comfort in income stability

Cut off ongoing SIPs completely to afford EMI outlay

in today's world, which is prone to mass layoffs. Increments may not come about as you hoped. Likewise, a severe illness or the need to care for ageing parents can sap your financial cushion. When a large EMI is ongoing, it leaves little margin for error and reduced ability to absorb shocks that life throws at you. This is when most borrowers sink deeper into crisis.

"Thin the buffer too much, and a single shock—a medical bill or a job loss—forces borrowers to turn to high-cost debt. That is often the moment a perfectly good home loan becomes the start of a wider spiral, and the point at which people reach us," remarks Srivastava of FREED. He insists that borrowers undertake a thorough stress test. Underwrite the loan against the birth of a child, a parent who needs support, or one income instead of two for a while. If it

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Filing return as an NRI?

Living abroad doesn't put you beyond taxman's radar

Miscounted days in India, missed NRO interest and TDS mismatches can invite notices from a data-savvy tax department.



by Preeti Kulkarni

For non-resident Indians (NRIs), filing an income tax return every year comes with unique compliance challenges, starting with determining tax residency status.

And, just as increased data-driven scrutiny by the income tax (IT) department has narrowed the scope for faulty disclosures by resident taxpayers, it has also raised the bar for NRIs to file accurate and compliant returns.

"The focus of NRI tax compliance has gradually shifted from tax computation to accurate reporting, reconciliation and documentation. With increased use of Annual Information Statement (AIS), Form 26AS, SFT (specified financial transactions) reporting and international exchange of information, even minor inconsistencies are getting flagged," says chartered accountant Mayank Mohanka, Founder, TaxAaram.com.

NRIs who were earlier resident in India continue to face a peculiar challenge. "First-time NRI return filers whose Permanent Account Number (PAN) and Aadhaar were linked while they were residents in India are unable to register on the e-filing portal with their current overseas mobile numbers. We advise such NRIs to retain their old Indian mobile numbers, wherever possible, to receive the Aadhaar OTP required for registration and for e-verifying their returns," says chartered accountant Himank Singla, Partner, SBHS Associates.

Tax residency status

This is the most crucial part of the return-filing exercise. Unlike resident and ordinarily resident (ROR) taxpayers, non-residents and resident but not ordinarily resident (RNOR) do not have to pay tax on income earned overseas. The residential status is determined based on physical presence in India under Section 6 of the Income Tax Act, 1961 (the new Income Tax Rules, 2026, will be applicable for ITR filing in the assessment year 2027-28). "An individual is resident if he

Taxpayers ought to carefully calculate the length of their stay and thus their residency status after poring over passport entries and immigration records.

is in India for 182 days or more in the previous year, or for 60 days or more in the previous year together with 365 days or more across the four preceding years. The lower 120-day limit applies only where Indian-sourced income (i.e. income other than from foreign sources) exceeds ₹15 lakh, which is uncommon for a salaried expatriate," says Naveen Wadhwa, Vice-president, Research,

Taxmann India.

Incorrectly ascertaining tax residency status can lead to errors in the computation of total income. Simply put, since even your foreign income can be taxed if you are an ROR, the quantum of your total income to be offered to tax can go up. "A non-resident is taxable only on income which is received or accrued or deemed to accrue or arise in India. A wrong 'resident' tag brings global income into the net," points out Wadhwa.

Many NRIs remain unclear about how their residential status is determined for tax purposes. "The biggest misconception is that visa status, a work permit, or residential status under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA) automatically determines tax residency. It does not. FEMA residential status governs foreign exchange transactions and banking rules, while tax residency is determined independently under Section 6 of the Income Tax Act, 1961, primarily on the basis of the prescribed day-count tests and, where applicable, the residency provisions of the relevant Double Taxation Avoidance Agreement (DTAA)."

says Mohanka. Taxpayers ought to carefully calculate the length of their stay and thus their residency status after poring over passport entries, immigration records, and boarding passes. "Even a difference of two or three days can materially alter the taxability of global income," he adds.

For Indian citizens and Persons of Indian Origin (PIO) visiting the country, there are some relaxations. "The law provides specified relaxations whereby, subject to the prescribed conditions, the 60-day threshold stands substituted by 120 days or 182 days, as the case may be," he says.

However, this should not be seen as an unrestrained leeway. "In the recent case of Binny Bansal versus Deputy Commissioner of Income Tax (DCIT), the Bangalore ITAT (Income Tax Appellate Tribunal) held that the expression 'being outside India' cannot be interpreted mechanically or through structured travel arrangements merely to secure the benefit of the extended 182-day threshold," points out Mohanka.

The appellate tribunal emphasised that the relaxation is intended for genuine non-residents visiting India, not as a tool to artificially avoid residential status. "The ruling reinforces that taxpayers should ensure that their travel pattern genuinely reflects residence abroad rather than relying solely upon a literal interpretation of the expression 'being outside India,'" he says.

Impact of US-Israel-Iran war

Some Indians visiting the Gulf countries in the last year have another peculiar problem to grapple with. Flight disruption and airspace closures in the region due to the ongoing United States-Iran-Israel war created situations where many were compelled to either extend their stay in India or were unable to return from overseas, potentially affecting their tax residency status. "While no specific Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) relaxation has been notified for Financial Year (FY) 2025-26, taxpayers facing such extraordinary circumstances may appropriately examine their position in the light of judicial precedents," says Mohanka, citing the Rajiv Saxena versus Deputy Director, Directorate of Enforcement case.

"The Delhi High Court recognised that compelled presence should not automatically trigger adverse tax consequences merely because the numerical day-count stands satisfied. Further, Raman Chopra versus DCIT (158 ITD 904) illustrates that where dual residence arises, the Article 4 tie-breaker provisions under the applicable DTAA may allocate treaty residence to the other country," he explains. In fact, the CBDT had announced a relaxation during the Covid-19 pandemic.

"The Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) has also observed that temporary and involuntary presence should ordinarily not alter treaty residence. Although these relaxations are not directly applicable today, they do provide persuasive interpretative guidance," adds Mohanka.

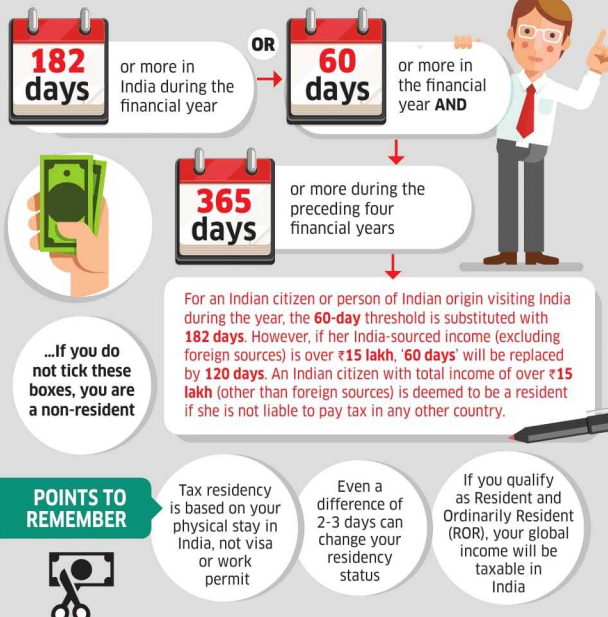
Property deals? Tread carefully

Several NRIs purchase and sell properties in India, triggering multiple tax rules, including those related to tax deducted

How your NRI status is determined

Take stock of number of days spent in India

You are a 'resident' if you satisfy either of these conditions:



The ITR filing to-do list for NRIs

- Determine residential status correctly
- Carefully count days spent in India
- Choose the correct ITR form; ITR-1, ITR-4 not for NRIs
- Reconcile AIS, 26AS and TIS
- Report taxable Indian income accurately
- Check TDS before filing returns
- Claim refunds for excess TDS, if any
- Claim eligible DTAA benefits, if applicable
- Obtain Tax Residency Certificate (TRC), File Form 67, if applicable
- NRO interest is taxable, NRE interest is exempt

at source (TDS). "Keep an eye on TDS mismatch, especially on property sales. On purchase of property from an NRI, tax is deductible under Section 195 at the applicable capital-gains rate (long-term or short-term) and not the 1% under Section 194-IA. NRIs often fail to apply for a lower/nil deduction

certificate under Section 197, suffer excess withholding, and then do not reconcile the credit against Form 26AS, AIS and Tax Information Summary (TIS)," explains Wadhwa.

While calculating your income and applicable TDS, ensure that you use the correct source for exchange rate conversion. "Income and TDS must be converted using the State Bank of India (SBI) telegraphic-transfer buying rate as prescribed under Rule 115, not an arbitrary or year-end rate," he advises.

Since declaring foreign assets and paying tax on overseas income apply only to ordinarily resident Indians, NRIs do not need to fill out the extensive Schedule FA (foreign assets) in the income tax return forms.

GIFT City income

Do NRIs need to report capital gains or other income generated by their GIFT City investments? "If NRIs just have exempt income from GIFT City investments, then they are not required to file their ITRs in India. However, if they have other taxable or reportable incomes in India necessitating filing of ITR, then they should also disclose this exempt income in EI Schedule," says Mohanka.

Dos and don'ts

NRIs cannot file their returns using the simple ITR-1 (Sahaaj) or ITR-4 (Sugam), as these are applicable only to ordinarily resi-

dent taxpayers. You can use ITR-2 if you earn salary, interest income or have clocked capital gains, and have no business income; else ITR-3, even if you are a salaried individual who dabbles in Futures and Options (F&O) and intra-day trading.

"Many NRIs mistakenly believe that the TDS deducted on their India-sourced income is their final tax liability. As a result, they often do not file an income tax return, even when they should. This can lead to either underpayment of taxes or failure to claim refunds of excess TDS," says Vishal Dhawan, Founder, Plan Ahead Wealth Advisors.

Many also fail to take advantage of the benefits available under the DTAA that India may have signed with their countries of residence, as they are unaware of the compliance requirements. "To claim treaty benefits, taxpayers may need to obtain a Tax Residency Certificate (TRC) from their country of residence and file Form 67 with the Indian tax authorities, where applicable," he says.

Many non-resident taxpayers also confuse NRE (non-resident external) bank accounts with NRO (non-resident ordinary) bank accounts when declaring related interest income in their ITR. An NRE account is primarily meant for parking foreign earnings remitted to India, while an NRO account is meant for managing income earned in India. "And, in the case of an NRE account, subject to fulfilment of the prescribed conditions, the interest earned is exempt from tax under Section 10(4)(ii). An NRO account is meant for managing income such as rent collected on property let out in India, dividends, pensions, and interest earned. A clear understanding of the purpose, taxability and reporting requirements of these two accounts is therefore essential for accurate tax compliance," says Mohanka.

The interest is fully taxable and also subject to TDS under Section 195. "Interest on NRE accounts is exempt from tax and interest on NRO accounts is fully taxable. Taxpayers routinely either miss NRO interest or wrongly claim exemption on it," says Wadhwa.

Let's take the case of an NRI A who has earned interest of ₹4 lakh on his NRE fixed deposit in 2025-26. In addition, NRO fixed deposit has yielded ₹2 lakh. "While the NRE interest may continue to remain exempt, subject to satisfaction of the prescribed conditions, the NRO interest is taxable in India and must be reported under the head 'Income from Other Sources', with credit being claimed for the TDS deducted," says Mohanka.

Also, even if your income earned in India is below the 87A tax rebate threshold—₹5 lakh under the old regime and ₹12 lakh under the new, default regime—you are not entitled to it. It is available only to resident Indians.

Too much riding on one AI stock? Techies see RSU concentration risk

With tech employees holding up to 80% of their net worth in a single stock, advisers say not selling is a real danger.

by Abhinav Kaul

Siddharth Eswaran, 38, a software engineer based in the United States, has spent his career inside America's biggest technology companies: Amazon and Uber and now at another major US-based tech company.

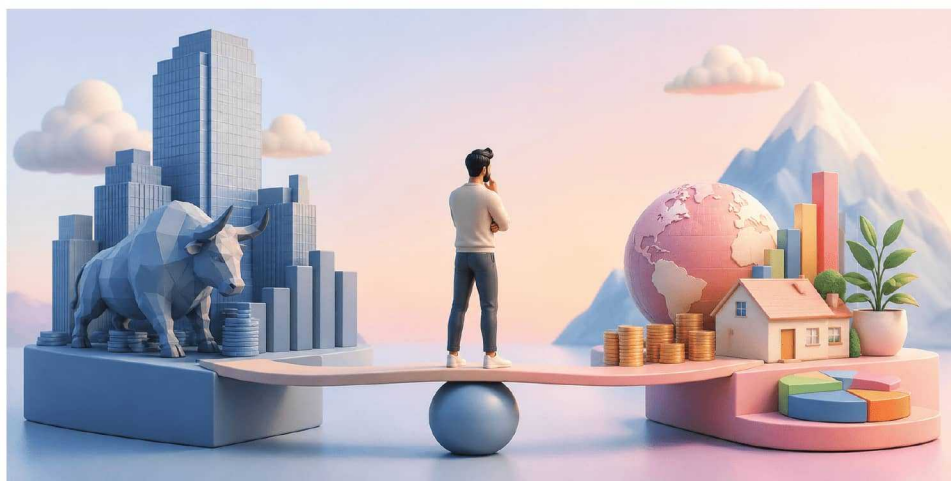
Along the way, each employer paid him large chunks of his compensation in restricted stock units (RSUs), most of which he held on to. In 2021, he sold his Amazon shares only to fund a down payment on a house in Seattle, Washington state, and dipped into his Uber stock in 2023 after a layoff.

Since then, rather than selling his RSUs, Eswaran has borrowed against his portfolio through a securities-backed line of credit, allowing the shares to compound. In recent times, however, his approach has changed.

"In my current job (company name withheld on request), I am selling shares as soon as they vest and then reinvest them in an S&P 500 index fund," says the 38-year-old. The trigger was months of weak sentiment and uncertainty about layoffs.

His older Amazon and Uber holdings stay put—partly because selling would trigger a large tax bill and partly because his adviser says the two stocks fall under different sectoral classifications, leaving him decently diversified.

Eswaran says had his entire net worth been in one stock, he would have considered diversifying a few years ago. His dilemma is playing out across thousands of households,



both in India and the US. The artificial intelligence (AI)-led rally in Meta, Alphabet, Microsoft, Nvidia and other tech company stocks has created enormous wealth for employees paid in stock. It has also left many with 50-80% of their net worth riding on a single company's shares. This larger concern is not whether AI stocks will crash; it is about portfolio construction.

How RSUs work

Millions of Indian professionals, both at home and in the US, are employed by American companies—especially those labelled 'Big Tech' such as Google parent

Alphabet, Amazon, and Microsoft—and receive RSUs or employee stock option (ESOPs) as a significant portion of their total compensation.

RSUs are shares that a company promises to give you for free, subject only to a vesting period, i.e. the time you must wait for these units to turn into stocks. You pay nothing to receive them. Once vested, they convert into actual shares in your brokerage account, and you can hold or sell them. For example, if you are granted 100 RSUs and 25 vest each year over four years, you receive 25 actual shares annually.

ESOPs work differently: they give you the right, but not the obligation, to buy shares at a pre-fixed price called 'strike price'. If the stock's market price rises above that strike price, you profit. If it does not, the options become worthless. ESOPs require you to pay to convert options into shares. RSUs do not.

The deeper problem is structural. Your salary and your portfolio depend on the same company. That's double the risk. When layoffs occur, salaries disappear, RSUs vest, bonuses stop, and ESOP values decline. Everything happens together.

The quiet exit

The selling has already begun, quietly. Vested Finance, an investment platform, has seen a 100% increase in fund flows from ESOP and RSU accounts since April, as employees increasingly look to diversify away from concentrated wealth in a single company, especially in the AI space.

The transfers are led by individuals

working at companies such as AMD, Intel, Microsoft, Google, Adobe and Qualcomm.

"Once it becomes more than 50-60% of your net worth, you should start diversifying," says Vested Finance CEO Viram Shah. "Ideally, 20-30% in one stock, especially where you're getting your income from, is the maximum (you should hold). Most people, until they are educated on this, are actually sitting on maybe 70-80% of their net worth in that stock, which is just too much risk."

At global investing platform Paasa, the destination of that money is striking. Co-founder and CEO Nitish Sahni says that for an employee moving their RSUs, 90% of the assets under management tend to go to UCITS ETFs—exchange-traded funds domiciled in Europe. The most popular funds on the platform include semiconductor, S&P 500 and emerging markets UCITS ETFs. International investors, including those outside the US, prefer UCITS ETFs primarily because they bypass harsh American tax laws, such as the 40% US estate tax and high dividend withholding rates.

Behaviour differs from company to company, according to Sahni. Employees holding stocks that have lagged, such as Adobe or Salesforce, "will want to diversify into better opportunities regardless of how the market is doing".

Those at Alphabet or Microsoft split into two camps: one sets a threshold below which they will sell; the other treats every dip as temporary because, as Sahni puts it, "AI is going nowhere".

How one US-based techie manages his RSUs



SIDDHARTH ESWARAN

Age: 38

Profession: Software engineer

Location: Seattle, Washington state

Current employer: Major US technology company

His RSU strategy

Amazon RSUs: Mostly continues to hold

Uber RSUs: Sold some in 2023

Current employer RSUs: Sells as soon as shares vests

Where does the money go?

Reinvests proceeds from current employer RSUs into a US S&P 500 index fund

The AI outlook

Experts are still optimistic on the AI segment. "It seems like earnings have actually kept up in the US markets," says Shah. "If you just broadly look at the S&P 500, there is still an opportunity for it to continue to give normal equity returns in the 8-10% range."

Inflows from Indian investors into US stocks have not slowed either, he adds.

However, Shobhit Mathur, co-founder of Ionic Wealth, argues that the valuation debate misses the point. "In tech, when disruptions happen, they take away a large part of your value proposition in a very short span of time. That unpredictability is the bigger problem area," he says.

His suggestion for believers in the AI wave is to own the ecosystem, not the employer. "Rather than picking individual companies, people are building a diversified basket."

Refusing to sell

The real hazard, advisers say, is not an AI correction. It is the employee who never sells. The reasons are rarely financial: loyalty, greed, anchoring to an old high, waiting for the "right price", and the fear of missing the next Nvidia.

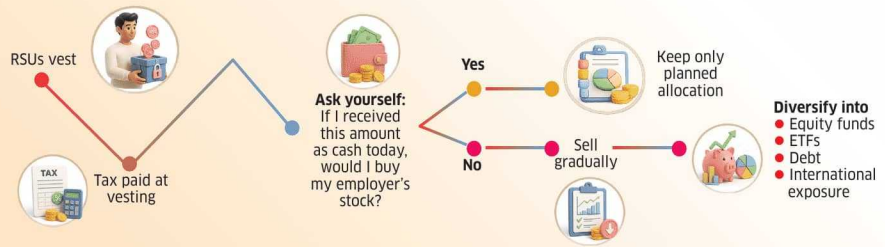
"Frankly, this is not a rational decision for many," according to Sahni. "For them, it holds sentimental value: having spent a number of years at the company, and acknowledging its role in their and their family's lives."

Mathur calls it familiarity bias. "Many continue to hold, and when a downfall of such magnitude happens, you are holding your largest position at the worst time."

He also punctures the illusion of inside knowledge: "If you're just one employee who has got these RSUs, your understanding of where the company is going is as much as somebody outside the company."

Sandeep Jethwani, co-founder of wealth management startup Dezerv, has observed the same psychology up close. "When your salary, your identity and your largest asset all come from one place, selling the stock can feel like a vote of no-confidence in your own

What should you do when RSUs vest?



employer, even your own career."

However, he warns that this argument is misplaced because "the company already has your time and your talent. It does not need your entire net worth as well."

The estate trap

For non-resident Indians (NRIs) and returning Indians, taxation adds a layer most discover too late. The sharpest edge is the US estate tax: for NRIs, US-situated assets above \$60,000 are subject to an estate tax of up to 40% on death.

"Assume somebody has amassed a million dollars of RSUs over five to seven years," says Mathur. "If something were to happen, that million dollars requires, as per US estate tax laws, 40% to be paid as estate duty before those assets can even be touched or accessed by the family members. That means \$400,000 needs to be set aside for taxes. India has LRS (Liberalised Remittance Scheme) limits capped at \$250,000. A lot of times, people have taken years before they could even get access to that money." His wealth management firm has come across a few such cases in the last couple of months.

The US system compounds the pain because, unlike India, brokerage accounts there have no nominee facility. "In the US, there is no concept of beneficiary or nominee. You need a will or a succession certificate before the broker starts processing the transfer," notes Sahni, recalling a Microsoft employee whose assets remain stuck in US probate. "Forget concentration risk, how will you get the assets back?"

For employees moving back to India, the transition window matters enormously, says Sidhant Agarwal, co-founder of India for NRI, a cross-border legal and taxation consulting firm. "If a person is not a green card holder and is moving back to India, we generally suggest they sell those RSUs while they are an RNOR (resident, but not ordinarily resident), because India won't have authority to tax that. The same logic applies to a 401(k), though there's a nuance—you can also elect under Section 89A to defer Indian tax on it until actual withdrawal, so selling isn't the only route."

"But if a withdrawal is coming either way, doing it during RNOR avoids the India-side tax entirely. Once you cross the RNOR phase, you become a permanent resident of India, and then the problem arises: India will subject that income to tax," Agarwal adds.

His general advice: "Either sell before leaving the US, or in the RNOR phase—and

According to experts, RSUs should not be thought of as investments in the first place. They are simply salary paid late, and in shares instead of cash.

and immediately used it to buy its own shares on your behalf. That raises the question Jethwani wants every employee to ask: "If you had been handed this amount in cash today, would you have gone out and bought your own employer's shares with it all? Almost nobody would. Most people who hold vested RSUs are doing it out of inertia and calling it conviction."

Where money goes

The advisers converge on the mechanics. Sell gradually, not in one call.

"Think of it like a staggered selling, as a systematic investment plan in reverse," says Jethwani. Holding on entirely or exiting entirely are both gambles, he observes, pointing to Nvidia, the chipmaker whose stock multiplied several times over during the AI boom and minted fortunes for those who stayed invested. "If you hold everything and the stock collapses, you have a problem; if you sell everything and it becomes the next Nvidia, you also have a problem. The answer to both regrets is the same: sell steadily over time."

Shah suggests a simple rule: "Every time you hit a 52-week high, just take something off. Study how Jeff Bezos has done it with his Amazon stock."

And avoid false diversification. "Selling one large-cap US tech name to buy three others leaves you exposed to the same factor: US mega-cap technology and AI sentiment," warns Jethwani. "You have one bet expressed four ways, not four bets."

Where should the proceeds go? Into broad ETFs and diversified, professionally managed portfolios; into UCITS funds for eligible investors, which sidestep US estate tax; into debt, where Sahni notes investors are already going "risk off" toward bond ETFs; and into Indian assets tied to goals. Mathur's current house view is a 70-30 split between Indian and global markets. The destination matters less than the principle, says Jethwani, adding, "The whole point of selling a concentrated position is to convert a fragile, single-point bet into a diversified portfolio that can survive any one company, sector or country having a bad decade."

for a 401(k), make sure the Section 89A election is filed in your very first resident year if you plan to hold rather than withdraw."

For resident Indians holding US employer stock, Agarwal explains, the tax bite is twofold: at vesting, when TDS is deducted at slab rates on the difference between the fair market value of the shares on the vesting date and whatever the employee actually paid for them, and again at sale, when capital gains apply to the appreciation, computed in rupees. Compliance starts immediately. "Right at the moment the shares hit your account, it becomes a reportable event in India" under Schedule FA, says Agarwal.

For very large estates, trusts in the US, India or both can mitigate estate tax. Agarwal, however, warns that "it is an expensive affair to form a trust. We generally do not advise it," unless the family and wealth structures are complex.

Cash, not conviction

So how much concentration is too much?

Jethwani offers a test rather than a number: "If a single position can be cut in half and materially change your life plans, it is no longer an investment. It is an exposure you have not chosen deliberately."

Shah puts the ceiling at 20-30%, while Sahni says the pain starts "20% onwards, mathematically speaking". Mathur notes that even seasoned fund managers rarely cross 10% in a single stock "because there are always unknown unknowns".

Jethwani goes a step further. RSUs, he argues, should not be thought of as investments in the first place. They are simply salary paid late, and in shares instead of cash. The tax treatment proves the point: an RSU is taxed at its full market value on the day it vests, exactly the way a cash bonus would be.

In other words, on vesting day, your employer has effectively handed you money

Estate tax alert

The hidden risk after building wealth.



Foreign degree, India campus

Foreign universities are setting up shop in India and charging less than their home campuses. Should you enrol?

by Riju Mehta

If you've had to defer or cancel your foreign education plans, there's good news—foreign education has come to India. With nearly 19 foreign universities, mostly from the United Kingdom (UK) and Australia, either already operational or set to start their sessions in Fall this year or in 2027, a brand-new set of higher education options has opened up for Indian students.

These institutions are ranked among the top 500 globally and include the Illinois Institute of Technology (US), the University of Liverpool, the University of Southampton, Victoria University, and The University of Western Australia (Australia), among others. Most of their Indian campuses are, as expected, in metros like Mumbai, Bengaluru, Delhi NCR, and GIFT City in Gujarat.

A degree from a foreign university without leaving India may seem to combine the best of both worlds, but will it deliver the low-cost, high-quality education people are looking for? More importantly, will a foreign degree in India offer the return on investment that justifies the higher fees compared to some of the Indian universities? Though the enrolment process has already begun at several of these universities, weigh the pros and cons before making a decision.

Why the influx now?

The unprecedented influx of foreign universities in the past two years is due to a combination of domestic policy changes and global upheavals, with the defining push clearly coming from vested commercial interests.

Indian market: The biggest reason is that India is not only among the world's largest higher education markets, with nearly 180 million people between the ages of 18 and 24, but also that Indian students represent the largest global cohort. "With over 13.35 lakh students choosing to study abroad in 2024, it represents an opportunity global universities can no longer ignore. Setting up campuses here is the natural next step," says Tripti Maheshwari, Co-Founder, Student Circus.

"Universities are simply following the demand rather than waiting for it to come to them," counters Sandeep Parekh, Managing Partner, Finsec



Foreign university campuses operational in India

University	Country	Session start	Indian campus	Programs (2026)	Study areas	Full course fee (2026)
Deakin University	Australia	Jul 2024	GIFT City, Gujarat	● 2 Master's (1.5 yrs)	Business analytics; Cyber security	₹25.8 lakh
University of Wollongong	Australia	Nov 2024	GIFT City, Gujarat	● 2 Graduate certificates (6 mths) ● 1 Bachelor's (3 yrs) ● 4 Master's (1.5-2 yrs)	Business analytics & finance; Computing science and information systems; Financial technology	Graduate certificate ₹6.1 lakh Bachelor's ₹33.2 lakh Master's ₹18.2 lakh
University of Southampton	UK	Sep 2025	Gurugram, Haryana	● 1 BEng. (hons, 3 yrs) ● 5 BSc (hons, 3 yrs) ● 4 MSc (1 yr)	Software engineering; Accounting & finance; Business management; Computer science; Creative computing; Economics; Data science; Finance; International management	BSc ₹41.6 lakh MSc ₹16.2 lakh
Queen's University Belfast	UK	Jan 2026	GIFT City, Gujarat	● 6 MSc (1 yr)	Business analytics; Financial analytics; Finance; Artificial intelligence; AI in business; Construction & project management	₹19.7 lakh

Source: University websites. Actual course fees and programs may vary.

Law Advisors. "For years, a large number of Indians have gone abroad to study, and the universities have come to depend on that fee income," he says. However, over the past two years, this number has dropped sharply, especially to favoured destinations such as Canada, the United States, the UK, and Australia. This is because of tighter visa policies, shorter post-study periods, higher visa and tuition fees, and rising cost of living due to the depreciating rupee. "Foreign universities have a strong commercial reason to set up campuses where the students already are," explains Parekh, who is also a visiting faculty at the Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad.

Policy change: The second reason is India's conscious bid to build India into a global education hub, retain talent, and reduce the foreign exchange that leaves the country for education. In 2020, a policy shift altered the market, from one where foreign institutions could only collaborate with Indian partners into one where they could set up and operate their own campuses. The National Education Policy 2020 allowed foreign universities ranked among the top 500 globally to establish campuses in India. The next turning point came with the University Grants Commission (UGC) issuing the UGC (Setting Up and Operation of Campuses of

Foreign Higher Educational Institutions in India) Regulations, 2023.

These regulations created a formal route for foreign universities to enter India, and have been supported by the GIFT City framework. "The regulations have come at a time of tightening visa regimes in the West, a young population hungry for global credentials, a deepening industry base, and being physically present in India simply makes more academic and commercial sense," says Arindam Banerjee, Professor, Finance & Accounting, and Director, Master of Applied Finance and Wealth Management, SP Jain School of Global Management.

"Besides, the regulations are generous to the foreign institutions, allowing them to decide fees without a government cap, recruit and pay faculty on their own terms, and repatriate the surplus, subject to our foreign exchange laws. This commercial freedom, which our own institutions don't enjoy, is itself an attraction," says Parekh.

What they offer

Currently, most universities offer a very limited number of undergraduate, post-graduate, and shorter courses compared to those provided by their parent campuses, with most leaning towards STEM (science, technology, engineering, and mathematics)

and business or finance disciplines. For instance, the University of Southampton in Gurugram offers only 10 courses versus over 400 offered by the parent university in UK.

"Compared to the extremely expensive campuses with extensive research facilities, libraries and laboratories abroad, the Indian universities are housed in very small spaces and have very few facilities as of now," says Mandeep Bachher, Co-founder, MindScan Education. Agrees Banerjee: "For the newly set up foreign university campuses, the program choice is narrower, faculty and research depth are nascent, and the wider campus life, alumni density and genuinely international classroom may take years to replicate."

The faculty models may also vary. While some global universities may rotate professors across campuses or bring in visiting faculty, others may rely more on locally recruited talent. However, the degree and curriculum will mirror those of the parent campus. "Branch campuses operate under the same academic standards and quality benchmarks of their parent institutions, with curriculum, assessment frameworks, and degree structures aligned with the university's requirements," says Ritika Singh, Executive Director, IC3 Movement.

"Students will graduate with the same

degree as those studying in Australia. The curriculum, academic standards, learning outcomes and quality assurance processes are fully aligned across campuses,” affirms Professor Jennifer Howell, Deputy Vice-Chancellor (Global Engagement) at The University of Western Australia, which is set to start its sessions in Mumbai (September 2026) and Chennai (2027).

While on paper there may be no difference in degrees and curriculum, they will lack global experience and exposure. “Studying overseas offers an immersion in a different culture, exposure to a diverse peer group, international faculty, extensive research infrastructure, experience of living and working in a global environment, and industry exposure that work to shape a student’s education,” says Pranet Singh, VP, University Partnerships, upGrad Study Abroad.

Affirms Parekh: “A leased building in Gurugram or at GIFT City, however well equipped, is not the same as a home campus spread over hundreds of acres with its libraries, laboratories, research culture and the wider university around it.”

Cost differential

However, there are benefits. Besides the savings that come from staying in India, the foreign universities are clearly cheaper than their parent campuses abroad. “The biggest advantage is affordability. Students can access an international degree while avoiding major expenses such as overseas accommodation, travel, visa costs and the significantly higher cost of living associated with studying abroad,” says Maheshwari.

However, these may cost the same as, or be more expensive than comparable Indian institutions. “Studying abroad typically costs ₹1-3 crore depending on the country and course, while the Indian campuses may cost 30-60% less. However, they may be more expensive than most public Indian universities, while being competitive with premium private institutions,” says Alok Bansal, Delhi-based career coach and consultant.

Agrees Banerjee: “Compared with some of India’s elite institutions, the picture is mixed. A top-tier institution or private university can cost the same or even less. So, the saving is real against going abroad, but not automatic against every Indian option.”

Depending on the university and program, the Indian branch may cost ₹20-25 lakh per year. “By comparison, the same program at the university’s UK campus could cost ₹30-36 lakh per year in tuition

Most foreign varsities are starting sessions in 2026

GIFT City, Gujarat

- University of Surrey UK
- Coventry University UK

Mumbai

- Illinois Institute of Technology US Aug-Sep 2026
- University of Bristol UK Aug 2026
- University of York UK Sep 2026
- University of Aberdeen UK Sep 2026
- The University of Western Australia Australia Sep 2026
- Istituto Europeo di Design Italy 2026-27

Delhi NCR

- Victoria University Australia Aug 2026

Greater Noida

- Western Sydney University Australia Aug 2026



Bangalore

- University of Liverpool UK Sep 2026
- Lancaster University UK
- Birkbeck, University of London UK Sep 2026
- UNSW Sydney Australia Aug 2026
- La Trobe University Australia

Source: University websites, government circulars.

fees alone, with the total annual cost rising to ₹50 lakh with accommodation and living expenses,” says Maheshwari. At the same time, premium Indian institutions such as the Indian School of Business (ISB) also charge tuition fees ranging from ₹39 lakh to over ₹50 lakh for their flagship programs.

Career potential

Though the heft of a foreign degree seems promising, career outcomes are uncertain because universities will take time to establish industry linkages and build recruiter trust, or promise ‘guaranteed’ placements. Students need to understand that being physically present in another country provides access to local employer networks, recruitment events and, in many destinations, post-study work opportunities that are difficult to replicate from India.

“The overseas campuses offer better access to global recruiters, international internships, larger alumni networks and graduate work visa opportunities. The Indian campuses will need time to establish comparable placement records,” says Bansal.

However, some of these campuses are

Cost comparison: Foreign varsities’ Indian campuses are more affordable

	Undergraduate	Postgraduate
University of Southampton (India)	₹41.6 lakh (3 yrs)	₹16.2 lakh (1 yr)
University of Southampton (UK)	₹96.4 lakh (3 yrs)	₹40.9 lakh (1 yr)
IIM Ahmedabad	NA	₹27.5 lakh (MBA 2 yrs) ₹35 lakh (PGPX, 1 yr)

Source: University websites. Figures are indicative course fees. Actual fees may vary.

Southampton UK undergraduate course is Business Management & postgraduate course is International Management; Southampton UK undergraduate course is Business Management & postgraduate course is Business Analytics & Management Science; IIMA courses are Master of Business Administration; PGPX is Post Graduate Programme in Management for Executives (fee includes tuition, stay, facilities, etc.)

located in industry centres—Gurugram, GIFT City, Bangalore and Powai next to the Indian Institute of Technology Bombay—which can translate into useful internships and local hiring opportunities.

“Rather than simply replicating what works on their home campuses, several global universities are creating India-specific employability strategies, signing industry partnerships and designing internship pathways that reflect the needs of the local job market. For example, the University of Bristol has established a dedicated working group at its parent campus to help shape employability strategies for its India campus,” says Maheshwari.

Confirms Howell: “UWA India will work closely with industry to support internships, career development and employment opportunities in India, while students will also have access to UWA’s global alumni, employer and career networks that enhance international career prospects.”

Should you opt for these?

If you are looking for a foreign education and plan to work in India, these may be a good option as you get an international degree at a lower cost. However, it will not open up a foreign residency pathway through post-study work visas that studying abroad grants. So if your intention is to gain foreign exposure, or work and settle abroad, this route may not work.

More importantly, placement and outcome data are scarce for these universities’ Indian branches, and the first few batches will carry the risk that later ones may not. “Evaluate the particular institution and program, ask hard questions about who will actually teach you and what the early cohorts’ results look like, and match the choice to your own goal,” says Parekh.

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Should you apply? Consider pros & cons

Advantages

- International degree without leaving India.
- Academic curriculum from a globally recognised top 500 institution.
- International teaching practices.
- Significantly lower cost compared to parent university abroad.
- Opportunity for global exposure through exchange programs.
- No visa uncertainty, high travel or living expenses while studying abroad.



Drawbacks

- No holistic exposure to an international ecosystem.
- Very few courses being currently offered.
- Local faculty, limited facilities, small campuses compared to parent university.
- Cost may be higher than Indian universities which may offer better career potential.
- It’s not the route to work or settle abroad. Likely to lead to placements, career options within India.

Financial freedom for child, US style

Two cultures, one crowded nest: how families on either side split the bills when grown-up children stay home.



UMA SHASHIKANT
CHAIRPERSON,
CENTRE FOR INVESTMENT
EDUCATION AND LEARNING

In the United States, those graduating in the 21st century especially have been seeking to return to the homes of their boomer parents. In India, in contrast, living with parents has remained a default option for young adults until they get married or move to another city for a job—an arrangement that is endorsed by tradition.

It is quite common for young adults in the United States to move out of their parents' home when they start college at age 18. Many of them study in-state (colleges within their state of residence) to benefit from lower fees. Those who are achievers in academics, sports, or art may also be eligible for scholarships. The general understanding is that from that point, young adults fend for themselves without making demands on their parents' retirement savings. This trend has changed over the years.

We now have the 'boomerang generation' that is again staying with their parents. What began as a temporary arrangement has now become a fairly entrenched trend, with a large chunk of middle-income homes reporting the "crowded nest" syndrome. Those graduating in the 21st century, especially, have returned to their boomer parents' homes. A mix of the financial crises of the early 2000s, rising burden of student loan debt and high interest rates, as well as the high costs of homeownership and rent has contributed to this trend.

In India, in contrast, living with parents has remained a default option for young adults until they get married or move to another city for a job. It is also common for the couple to live with the groom's parents—an arrangement that is endorsed by tradition as well as offers convenience and support for both the young couple and the parents. In recent years, we see a rising preference among both parents and their adult children to live separately. What are the personal finance implications of this co-habitation? How similar or different are these arrangements in India and in the US?

Same roof, different rules

First, it is very common for American parents to specify a time period till which their adult child will live with them. Usually, the child is looking for a job, setting up something new on their own, has a student loan repayment, or wishes to save money for a down payment on a home. It is also not uncommon for parents to collect a nominal rent. In the Indian context, the arrangement is informal and the duration is not defined. Parents hesitate to ask their child to move out. Children also see it as a delicate or inconvenient matter to bring up, or may choose specific milestones, such as a job change or marriage, to bring up the issue.

Second, tax laws in the US treat monetary transfers of any kind to an adult child as a gift, taxable beyond specific limits for the parents. Indian tax laws do not impose any limits on gifts exchanged between close relatives, such as a parent and child. American parents cannot offer to repay their child's education loan, buy a house or car, or make monthly allowances without tax implications for reporting, disclosure and staying within exempt limits. Indian parents can do all of these acts of benevolence for their adult children without worrying about taxes. Therefore, parents patronising adult children and meeting expectations for monetary support remain commonplace in India but are exceptional in the US.



Third, the American way of life demands a certain level of independence from adults. There is no expectation that someone else will cook, clean or care for them unless they have taken ill or have expressly asked for help. The cultural expectation is that an adult child living with their parents should not make these demands. Nor will the parents ask or offer such everyday care. Eating out and cooking together would happen, but as part of a plan, not as a routine. In Indian culture, food is a central part of expressing love, care, and concern. Many mothers still cook, launder, and clean for their adult children without complaint. In many households, planning one's meals without including the others is a strict no-no.

Fourth, India has a low-cost labour model that reduces the burden of household management. It is relatively easy to hire and pay for help to cook, clean, drive and do other routine chores. In the US, most of these services are routinely affordable only to very high-income families. The American household lays down rules on who does the dishes, mows the lawn, takes out the trash, and makes grocery runs; the Indian household has to figure out how to split the costs of these common services between the parent and the adult children.

Fifth, healthcare is expensive in the US. Hence, it is widely understood that adults will be responsible for paying for their health insurance or seek Medicare benefits as eligible and offered by the state. Children beyond a certain age cannot remain on the health insurance of their parents, and parents are not included in the cover their children's employers offer. In India, it is common for children to include parents in their insurance plan or pay for medical care, including hospitalisation. This is broadly true even if the adult child does not live with the parent. When they live with their parents, the added costs of caregiving are also borne by the adult children.

Ground rules for the crowded nest

How do these broad differences impact the personal finances of the household?

For one, segregating expenses and budgeting for them is challenging when adult children live with their parents. Groceries, utilities and maintenance are all incurred for the house as a unit, and might be difficult to apportion. Personal expenses that are easily identified can be incurred separately. It is not unusual for parents to ask for a monthly payment to cover these costs. It remains culturally easier to do so in the US than it is in India.

Earmarking an amount as rent can help, as some parents may save it for a future large expense of their children. It also helps parents who are retired and have to draw from their retirement corpus. It can be a nominal amount, but setting it aside helps both sides.

Expenses that can't be subsidised

It also helps to define the subsidies, and ensuring both parties agree to them right at the start can help avoid future conflicts. Using the car and the driver, utilising the parents' services for babysitting and child care, are all instances of subsidy that blow up over time. Where an expense can be specifically earmarked and incurred by the party using the service, it is better not to subsidise it.

The young adult has a higher requirement for long-term savings and asset building. Older parents are at a stage where they would draw down what they have saved over long working years. Differences in life stage will result in different orientations towards spending, borrowing, saving, investing, and giving. Keeping these financial decisions independent helps both sides.

Merging two households into one and hoping that the arrangement would be without friction is a fantasy, whether in India or in the US. Establishing ground rules and working within the cultural context can help understand what might work and what might not.

Jio IPO sparks interest

Dialling into telecom growth

Strong revenue growth, rising data demand and a landmark Jio IPO signal a favourable sector outlook.

by Sameer Bhardwaj

Jio Platforms' proposed initial public offering (IPO), expected over the next few quarters, is set to be a landmark event for India's telecom sector. The issue could rank among the country's largest IPOs, giving investors direct exposure to Reliance Jio Infocomm, India's largest telecom operator by subscriber base.

The IPO comes at a time when the industry cycle is strengthening, supported by rising average revenue per user (ARPU), steady growth in data consumption, and a moderation in capital expenditure intensity.

Investor optimism in the sector is evident in recent market performance. The BSE Telecom Index has delivered 14.5% year-to-date returns in 2026, emerging as the third-best performing sector index after power and capital goods. In comparison, the benchmark BSE Sensex has declined 9.9% over the same period, based on closing data as of 29 June 2026.

Jio Platforms' IPO

Jio Platforms, the digital services arm of Reliance Industries, has filed draft papers with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) for an initial public offering. The issue will primarily comprise a fresh equity issuance, meaning most of the proceeds will flow to the company. This contrasts with the proposed National Stock Exchange (NSE) initial public offering, which is expected to be an offer for sale, allowing existing shareholders to monetise their stakes.

The company plans to use the IPO proceeds to reduce debt in its telecom business, while also investing in network expansion, artificial intelligence (AI) infrastructure, and the growth of its digital services ecosystem. According to Gaurav Bhandari, Chief Executive Officer of Monarch Network Capital, the listing will give investors direct exposure to India's largest telecom and digital platform, while improving transparency and capital allocation discipline. He expects the IPO to accelerate investments in adjacent digital businesses, with industry competition remaining rational as operators focus on returns.

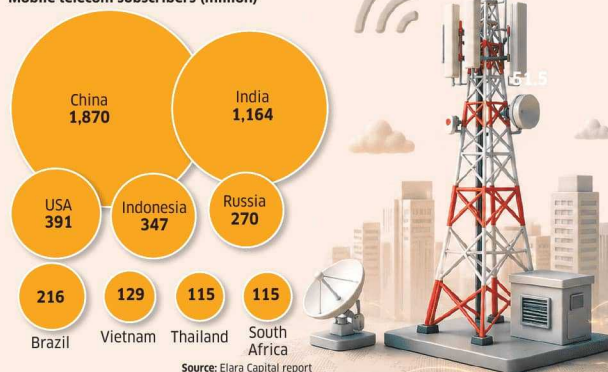
Sector tailwinds

India is the world's second-largest mobile connectivity market, yet mobile broadband penetration at 68.5% indicates significant room for growth.

The scale advantage

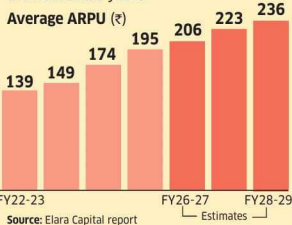
India ranks among the largest telecom markets globally.

Mobile telecom subscribers (million)



Revenue momentum

India's average revenue per user (ARPU) is expected to grow at a compound annual growth rate of 7% over the next three years.



Rising disposable incomes, an improving device ecosystem, and the proliferation of new digital use cases are expected to deepen user engagement and accelerate adoption.

Analysts expect steady growth in the telecom sector over Financial Year (FY) 2026-27, supported by likely tariff hikes, ongoing premiumisation and a healthier 4G/5G subscriber mix. Expanded network coverage, increasing monetisation of 5G services, and growth in broadband and enterprise segments are likely to remain key drivers. An Axis Direct report (June 2026) estimates sector revenue growth of 11-13% over this period. Leading players such as Bharti Airtel and Reliance Jio are focusing on monetising 5G investments through fixed wireless access, enterprise solutions, and premium data offerings. The expansion of enterprise services is also expected to aid margin improvement and support profitability.

According to an Elara Capital report

(June 2026), the telecom sector is in a multi-year recovery, supported by rising ARPUs, structural growth in data demand and lower incremental capital expenditure. The brokerage expects ARPU to grow at a 7% compound annual rate between FY26 and FY29, driving earnings upgrades, balance sheet deleveraging and stronger free cash flow generation.

Experts advise viewing the sector as a structural cash flow and pricing power story rather than a high-growth thematic play. Anil R., Senior Research Analyst at Geojit Investments, recommends a 5-10% portfolio allocation to the sector, subject to valuation comfort. He emphasises a higher allocation to market leaders that offer strong balance sheets. On valuations, Bhandari notes that while telecom stocks may not appear inexpensive in absolute terms, they remain reasonable when assessed against improving industry fundamentals such as rising ARPUs, increasing data consumption, and long-term digital infrastructure opportunities. He suggests that investors consider accumulating quality telecom businesses during market corrections.

Risks

While the telecom sector's long-term outlook remains positive, analysts caution that delays in tariff hikes pose a key near-term risk. In a June 2026 report, UBS said operators may postpone tariff increases due to macroeconomic pressures, including the West Asia conflict and elevated inflation. The brokerage expects a 10% tariff hike in the third quarter of the current financial year but warned it could be pushed to FY28 if conditions remain unfavourable. Anil R. also flagged Vodafone Idea's financial stress as a key factor influencing competitive intensity

in the sector. He pointed to risks such as potential short-term valuation-led dislocations from the proposed Jio IPO and the possibility of regulatory interventions that could impact pricing power or ARPU realisation. Here is how the three key telecom players are placed:

Bharti Airtel

- Reported strong revenue growth in the March 2026 quarter, supported by steady momentum in India operations and a robust contribution from the Africa business.
- Continued investments in network quality and capacity expansion remain a priority, alongside scaling adjacencies such as data centres (targeting 1GW capacity), NBFC-led financial services, and sovereign cloud offerings to drive diversification.
- ARPU growth is likely to be aided by a better subscriber mix, including postpaid upgrades, continued migration from 4G to 5G, and rising data consumption.
- The Africa segment offers meaningful long-term opportunities, driven by favourable demographics, increasing smartphone penetration.
- Elara Capital says a progressive dividend policy, improving return ratios and steady earnings growth could drive a valuation re-rating over time.

Jio Platforms (Reliance Jio)

- Reliance Jio contributed 88% to Jio Platforms' consolidated revenue, underlining its key role in the group's digital ecosystem.
- Reliance Jio reported 13% year-on-year revenue growth and an 8% increase in ARPU in FY26.
- Free cash flow improved during the year, driven by efficient working capital management and a moderation in expenditure.
- Motilal Oswal expects Jio to remain the key growth driver for Reliance Industries, with earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortization (EBITDA) projected to grow at a compounded rate of 18% between FY26 and FY28.
- Future growth is expected to be led by tariff hikes, market share gains, and expansion in home broadband and enterprise segments.

Vodafone Idea

- Reported 5% year-on-year revenue growth in the March 2026 quarter, supported by subscriber stabilisation.
- Management remains confident about servicing liabilities through internal cash generation over FY26 to FY29.
- Analysts caution that a sustained turnaround will depend on tariff hikes, subscriber stabilisation, and further relief on spectrum payments.

Stocks mentioned are not recommendations. Consult your financial adviser.

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ETW FUNDS 100

BEST FUNDS TO BUILD YOUR PORTFOLIO

ET Wealth collaborates with Value Research to identify the top-performing funds across categories. Equity funds and equity-oriented hybrid funds are ranked on 3-year returns while debt-oriented hybrid and income funds are ranked on 1-year returns.

	Value Research Fund Rating	Net Assets (₹ Cr)	RETURNS (%)					Expense Ratio (%)
			3-Month	6-Month	1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	
EQUITY: LARGE CAP								
Nippon India Large Cap	*****	51,660	8.4	-4.6	-2.1	13.3	15.3	1.2
ICICI Prudential Large Cap	*****	76,297	7.0	-6.5	-3.0	13.1	13.4	1.1
HDFC Large Cap	*****	37,808	8.7	-5.2	-2.7	10.9	12.5	1.3
EQUITY: FLEXI CAP								
Bank of India Flexi Cap	****	2,460	14.5	5.7	7.2	20.6	16.5	1.7
Invesco India Flexi Cap	****	4,956	19.2	2.0	0.0	18.4	-	1.6
HDFC Flexi Cap	*****	1,01,822	9.3	-3.0	0.8	17.1	17.9	1.1
HSBC Flexi Cap	****	5,538	15.0	1.4	1.5	16.6	14.2	1.6
JM Flexicap	****	5,069	15.0	1.1	-2.0	15.9	16.6	1.6
ICICI Prudential Flexicap	****	21,189	13.3	-0.3	6.1	15.7	-	1.4
Edelweiss Flexi Cap	****	3,374	9.4	-3.7	-0.4	14.5	13.4	1.7
Parag Parikh Flexi Cap	*****	1,41,447	4.4	-5.2	-3.2	14.0	13.8	1.1
Franklin India Flexi Cap	****	18,797	8.5	-4.6	-4.6	13.9	13.6	1.4
EQUITY: FOCUSED								
Invesco India Focused	****	5,273	20.2	5.2	-1.3	21.1	15.8	1.6
ICICI Prudential Focused Equity	*****	16,147	11.4	-4.2	2.0	18.2	16.6	1.4
HDFC Focused	*****	26,082	9.4	-3.5	0.0	16.7	18.9	1.4
Mahindra Manulife Focused	****	2,177	7.7	-1.7	-0.2	16.0	14.8	1.7
EQUITY: MULTI CAP								
Kotak Multicap	*****	26,249	11.8	-0.9	5.0	19.5	-	1.4
Axis Multicap	*****	9,938	14.6	2.7	3.5	19.2	-	1.5
ICICI Prudential Multicap	****	17,676	15.9	4.9	5.9	17.8	16.2	1.4
Nippon India Multi Cap	****	53,411	11.7	0.5	0.3	16.7	19.3	1.2
EQUITY: MID CAP								
Invesco India Mid Cap	****	12,397	23.1	7.1	8.7	25.3	20.3	1.5
Edelweiss Mid Cap	*****	16,849	14.8	2.5	3.9	22.4	19.0	1.4
Nippon India Growth Mid Cap	*****	47,415	15.3	5.6	6.4	22.1	20.5	1.2
Sundaram Mid Cap	****	13,687	13.3	2.0	5.5	21.2	18.3	1.5
HDFC Mid Cap	*****	97,350	11.9	0.7	4.2	19.9	19.9	1.1
Kotak Midcap	****	64,749	15.6	5.0	5.5	19.6	17.1	1.2
EQUITY: SMALL CAP								
Bandhan Small Cap	*****	27,219	18.1	6.6	5.3	27.1	19.7	1.4
Invesco India Smallcap	*****	11,717	24.2	11.5	9.6	23.8	20.2	1.5
Quant Small Cap	****	31,774	24.7	11.4	8.0	20.7	19.5	1.3
Nippon India Small Cap	*****	74,604	19.9	8.8	4.4	18.4	20.1	1.1
EQUITY: VALUE ORIENTED								
HSBC Value	****	14,548	9.2	-1.1	1.2	19.3	17.4	1.5
Axis Value	****	1,587	10.9	-0.4	3.8	18.1	-	1.8
DSP Value	*****	1,824	8.9	1.7	8.9	17.5	13.4	1.8
Nippon India Value	****	8,821	9.6	-3.6	-2.0	17.0	15.6	1.5
ICICI Prudential Value	*****	58,954	4.5	-7.5	-2.9	15.1	16.4	1.2
SBI Contra	****	47,263	5.9	-6.4	-4.1	13.4	16.6	1.3
EQUITY: ELSS								
Motilal Oswal ELSS Tax Saver	*****	4,663	18.4	10.5	4.4	22.0	17.9	1.6
SBI ELSS Tax Saver	*****	30,955	9.6	-4.0	-1.7	17.6	16.7	1.3
HDFC ELSS Tax Saver	*****	15,367	7.1	-6.9	-4.7	15.0	16.1	1.4
DEBT: SHORT DURATION								
ICICI Prudential Short Term	****	21,229	2.6	3.1	6.1	7.5	6.6	0.9
Axis Short Duration	*****	8,734	2.5	3.0	5.8	7.4	6.3	0.8
HDFC Short Term Debt	****	14,864	2.4	3.0	5.8	7.5	6.4	0.6
Nippon India Short Duration	****	7,247	2.4	2.9	5.6	7.3	6.2	0.8
SBI Short Term Debt	****	13,839	2.3	2.7	5.3	7.1	6.1	0.7
DEBT: CORPORATE BOND								
ICICI Prudential Corporate Bond	*****	31,740	2.8	3.2	6.2	7.6	6.7	0.5
Bandhan Corporate Bond	****	13,484	2.7	3.4	5.7	7.3	6.0	0.6
Axis Corporate Bond	****	8,359	2.7	3.0	5.5	7.4	6.3	0.8
Kotak Corporate Bond	****	15,990	2.4	2.7	5.3	7.4	6.3	0.6
Nippon India Corporate Bond	****	9,393	2.6	2.9	5.3	7.4	6.6	0.7
DEBT: LIQUID								
Axis Liquid	****	56,168	1.9	3.4	6.4	7.0	6.2	0.2
Bank of India Liquid	*****	1,720	1.8	3.3	6.4	7.0	6.2	0.1
DSP Liquidity	****	19,019	1.8	3.3	6.3	6.9	6.1	0.2
Aditya Birla Sun Life Liquid	****	47,520	1.8	3.3	6.3	6.9	6.2	0.3
Invesco India Liquid	*****	14,989	1.8	3.3	6.3	6.9	6.1	0.2
Union Liquid	****	8,782	1.8	3.3	6.3	6.9	6.2	0.2

13.3

THE 3-YEAR RETURN OF NIPPON INDIA LARGE CAP FUND IS THE HIGHEST IN ITS CATEGORY.

25.3%

THE 3-YEAR RETURN OF INVESCO INDIA MID CAP FUND IS THE HIGHEST IN ITS CATEGORY.

6.1%

THE 3-YEAR RETURN OF ICICI PRUDENTIAL SHORT TERM FUND IS THE HIGHEST IN ITS CATEGORY.

LAGGARDS & LEADERS

Taking a long-term view of fund returns, here is a list of 10 funds in each category—five leaders and five laggards.

LAGGARDS LEADERS

Equity: Large cap 3-year returns

6.0	19.0
LIC MF BSE Sensex Index	UTI Nifty Next 50 ETF
6.5	18.9
Tata BSE Sensex Index	ABSL Nifty Next 50 ETF
6.6	18.9
Nippon India Index - BSE Sensex	SBI Nifty Next 50 ETF
6.6	18.9
SBI BSE Sensex Index	Mirae Asset Nifty Next 50 ETF
6.7	18.9
HDFC BSE Sensex Index	ICICI Prudential Nifty Next 50 ETF

Equity: Flexi cap 3-year returns

-1.1	22.2
Samco Flexi Cap	SBI Children's - Investment
7.0	21.9
Tata Children's	ICICI Pru Retirement - Pure Equity
7.3	20.6
UTI Flexi Cap	Bank of India Flexi Cap
8.2	18.7
Shriram Flexi Cap	ITI Flexi Cap
8.5	18.4
UTI Children's Equity	Invesco India Flexi Cap

Equity: Mid cap 3-year returns

10.6	26.3
Taurus Mid Cap	HSBC Midcap
11.6	25.3
PGIM India Midcap	Invesco India Mid Cap
12.7	23.7
SBI Midcap	ICICI Prudential Midcap
13.4	23.0
UTI Mid Cap	WhiteOak Capital Mid Cap
15.6	22.4
Quant Mid Cap	Edelweiss Mid Cap

Equity: Small cap 3-year returns

11.9	27.1
Tata Small Cap	Bandhan Small Cap
13.0	24.9
ICICI Prudential Smallcap	ITI Small Cap
13.1	23.8
Kotak Small Cap	Invesco India Smallcap
13.3	23.0
SBI Small Cap	ABSL Nifty Smallcap 50 Index
13.4	23.0
HDFC Small Cap	Kotak Nifty Smallcap 50 Index

Hybrid: Aggressive 3-year returns

7.1	19.3
HDFC Hybrid Equity	ICICI Pru Retirement - Hybrid Aggressive
8.2	19.0
Axis Children's	Bol Mid & Small Cap Equity & Debt
8.3	15.9
LIC MF Unit Linked Insurance	ICICI Prudential Equity & Debt
8.5	14.7
PGIM India Aggressive Hybrid Equity	ICICI Prudential Children's
8.5	14.5
HDFC Retirement Savings - Hybrid Equity	Quant Aggressive Hybrid

ANNUALISED RETURNS IN % AS ON 1 JULY 2026

ETW FUNDS 100

DEBT: BANKING AND PSU

	Value Research Fund Rating	Net Assets (₹ Cr)	3-Month	6-Month	1-Year	3-Year	5-Year	Expense Ratio (%)
ICICI Prudential Banking & PSU Debt	★★★★	8,943	2.7	3.0	5.8	7.3	6.5	0.6
Bandhan Banking and PSU	★★★★	12,044	2.7	3.4	5.7	7.1	6.1	0.6
Axis Banking & PSU Debt	★★★★	12,219	2.4	2.8	5.4	7.0	6.0	0.5

DEBT: GILT

ICICI Prudential Gilt	★★★★★	8,608	4.6	3.3	4.8	7.4	6.6	0.9
Axis Gilt	★★★★★	424	4.8	3.7	4.5	7.4	6.0	0.7
UTI Gilt	★★★★	544	3.0	3.4	4.3	6.8	5.8	0.9
SBI Gilt	★★★★	8,695	3.4	3.0	3.6	6.5	6.1	0.8
HDFC Gilt	★★★★	2,080	4.5	2.9	3.5	6.6	5.6	0.8
Baroda BNP Paribas Gilt	★★★★	658	4.2	2.6	2.7	6.7	5.7	0.4

HYBRID: AGGRESSIVE

Bank of India Mid & Small Cap Equity & Debt	★★★★★	1,554	14.5	8.0	7.4	19.0	15.2	1.8
ICICI Prudential Equity & Debt	★★★★★	50,033	6.6	-1.5	2.8	15.9	16.8	1.2
Kotak Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	8,670	10.5	1.4	3.0	13.2	12.1	1.5
Edelweiss Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	3,667	7.6	-1.3	-0.3	13.2	13.1	1.6
Mahindra Manulife Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	2,310	5.9	-4.7	-3.2	12.4	11.8	1.7
UTI Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	6,473	5.9	-3.7	-1.3	12.2	12.3	1.5
Nippon India Aggressive Hybrid	★★★★	3,937	7.7	-1.4	0.9	11.7	11.4	1.6

HYBRID: CONSERVATIVE

Nippon India Conservative Hybrid	★★★★★	956	3.2	2.2	6.3	8.1	7.9	1.5
Parag Parikh Conservative Hybrid	★★★★★	3,345	3.4	3.1	5.3	10.7	9.6	0.5
SBI Conservative Hybrid	★★★★	9,793	5.3	2.7	4.9	8.9	8.9	1.2
ICICI Prudential Regular Savings	★★★★★	3,302	4.3	1.4	4.3	9.0	8.6	1.4
HDFC Hybrid Debt	★★★★	3,218	3.9	0.5	2.0	8.1	8.2	1.4

HYBRID: EQUITY SAVINGS

HSBC Equity Savings	★★★★★	1,016	8.1	7.0	11.1	13.1	11.0	1.3
Edelweiss Equity Savings	★★★★★	1,365	5.3	2.7	6.5	10.7	8.9	1.4
Kotak Equity Savings	★★★★	10,108	4.7	0.0	4.5	9.8	9.5	1.5
UTI Equity Savings	★★★★	823	3.0	-1.2	2.5	8.4	8.6	1.5
DSP Equity Savings	★★★★	3,478	3.0	0.2	2.3	8.4	7.7	1.3
ICICI Prudential Equity Savings	★★★★	16,733	2.0	-0.8	2.5	7.1	7.2	0.8

HYBRID: ARBITRAGE

Invesco India Arbitrage	★★★★	28,062	1.6	3.0	6.0	6.9	6.2	0.9
Kotak Arbitrage	★★★★★	72,079	1.6	3.1	6.0	7.0	6.2	0.8
UTI Arbitrage	★★★★★	10,991	1.5	3.0	6.0	7.0	6.0	0.7
SBI Arbitrage Opportunities	★★★★★	43,266	1.5	3.0	6.0	6.9	6.2	0.8
ICICI Prudential Arbitrage	★★★★	32,260	1.6	3.0	6.0	6.9	6.0	0.8
Tata Arbitrage	★★★★	22,760	1.5	3.0	6.0	6.8	5.9	0.9

HYBRID: DYNAMIC ASSET ALLOCATION

ICICI Prudential Balanced Advantage	★★★★	70,570	6.7	-0.3	4.6	11.7	10.9	1.2
Aditya Birla Sun Life Balanced Advantage	★★★★	9,253	7.2	0.6	3.1	11.2	9.8	1.5
Nippon India Balanced Advantage	★★★★	9,574	7.1	0.2	2.7	10.8	9.5	1.5
SBI Balanced Advantage	★★★★	40,673	5.0	-1.7	1.8	10.7	-	1.3
HDFC Balanced Advantage	★★★★★	1,04,016	6.5	-2.7	-0.6	14.0	15.1	1.1

HYBRID: MULTI ASSET ALLOCATION

SBI Multi Asset Allocation	★★★★	18,290	6.4	1.5	11.1	16.3	13.4	1.1
ICICI Prudential Multi Asset	★★★★★	84,165	4.6	-2.0	5.5	16.0	17.3	1.1

EQUITY: LARGE CAP

Kotak Nifty Next 50 Index	0.10*	1,163	16.4	3.6	4.9	18.1	13.4	0.4
Navi Nifty 50 Index	0.03*	3,907	6.3	-7.8	-5.3	8.6	-	0.3
ICICI Prudential BSE Sensex Index	0.03*	1,798	5.6	-9.3	-7.4	6.8	8.9	0.3

EQUITY: FLEXI CAP

SBI Nifty 500 Index	0.04*	760	10.5	-3.3	-2.0	-	-	0.7
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EQUITY: MID CAP

SBI Nifty Midcap 150 Index	0.05*	1,094	14.9	2.0	3.9	19.0	-	0.7
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All equity funds ranked on 3-year returns. Debt funds ranked on 1-year returns. Percentages rounded to one decimal place.



Did not find your fund here? Log on to www.wealth.economictimes.com for an exhaustive list.

Methodology

The Top 100 includes actively managed funds that have a 5- or 4-star rating from Value Research. The rating of a fund vis-à-vis other funds in its category is determined by subtracting a fund's risk score from its return score. The resulting number is assigned stars according to the following distribution:

- ★★★★★ Top 10%
- ★★★★ Next 22.5%
- ★★★ Middle 35%
- ★★ Next 22.5%
- ★ Bottom 10%

Debt funds and arbitrage funds with less than 18 months performance history and equity and hybrid funds with less than three-years performance track record are not rated. This ensures that all the funds have existed long enough to be tracked for consistency of performance. The top 100 funds also include index funds tracking mainstream indices, with more than one year history of efficient tracking. The fund categories considered are:

Fund categories

Equity: Large Cap: Funds investing at least 80% in large cap stocks.
Equity: Flexi Cap: Funds investing at least 65% in equity with no particular cap on large, mid or small.
Equity: Focused: Funds investing at least 80% in up to 30 equity stocks, with no particular cap on large, mid or small.
Equity: Multi Cap: Funds investing at least 25% each in large, mid & small caps.
Equity: Mid Cap: Funds investing at least 65% in mid caps.
Equity: Small Cap: Funds investing at least 65% in small caps.
Equity: Value Oriented: Funds following value/contrarian investment strategy, and grouped under 'Value' or 'Contrast' categories as per SEBI.
Equity: ELSS: Funds with a lock-in of 3 years and tax benefits under Section 80C.
Hybrid: Aggressive: Funds investing 65-80% in equity, and the rest in debt.
Hybrid: Conservative: Funds investing 10-

25% in equity, and the rest in debt.
Hybrid: Equity Savings: Funds investing at least 65% in equity and equity-related instruments, and at least 10% in debt.
Hybrid: Dynamic Asset Allocation: Funds which dynamically manage the asset allocation between equity and debt.
Hybrid: Multi Asset Allocation: Funds investing in at least 3 different asset classes, with a minimum of 10% in each.
Hybrid: Arbitrage: Funds investing in arbitrage opportunities.
Debt: Short Duration: Funds with Macaulay duration between 1 & 3 years at portfolio level.
Debt: Corporate Bond: Funds investing at least 80% in AA+ and above-rated corporate bonds.
Debt: Banking and PSU: Funds investing at least 80% in debt instruments of banks, PSUs, public financial institutions & municipal bonds.
Debt: Liquid: Funds investing in debt & money-market securities with maturity of up to 91 days.
Debt: Gilt: Funds investing at least 80% in government securities.

4.8%
THE 1-YEAR RETURN OF ICICI PRUDENTIAL GILT FUND IS THE HIGHEST IN ITS CATEGORY.

6.3%
THE 1-YEAR RETURN OF NIPPON INDIA CONSERVATIVE HYBRID FUND IS THE HIGHEST IN ITS CATEGORY.

6.0%
THE 1-YEAR RETURN OF INVESCO INDIA ARBITRAGE FUND IS THE HIGHEST IN ITS CATEGORY.

1 Top 5 SIPs

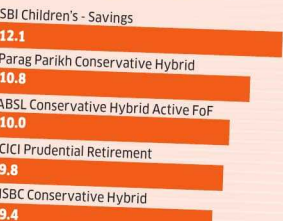
Top 5 equity schemes based on 10-year SIP returns



SIP: SYSTEMATIC INVESTMENT PLAN % ANNUALISED RETURNS AS ON 1 JULY 2026

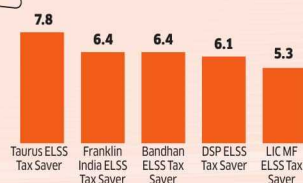
2 Top 5 SWPs

Top 5 conservative hybrid schemes based on 3-year SWP returns



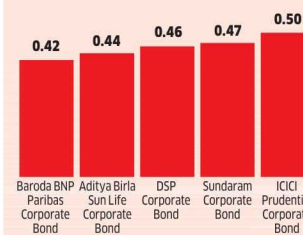
SWP: SYSTEMATIC WITHDRAWAL PLAN % ANNUALISED RETURNS AS ON 1 JULY 2026

3 Cash holdings ELSS



% OF ASSETS AS ON 31 MAY 2026

4 Expense ratio Debt: Ultra-short duration



% expense ratio is charged annually. Methodology of Top 100 funds on www.wealth.economictimes.com

FUND RAISER

₹1,345 cr

Net outflows from both gold & other ETFs in May. Negative net flow in these categories marks the first such instance in the last one year.

Source: AMFI

Mostly vanity, occasionally the taxman

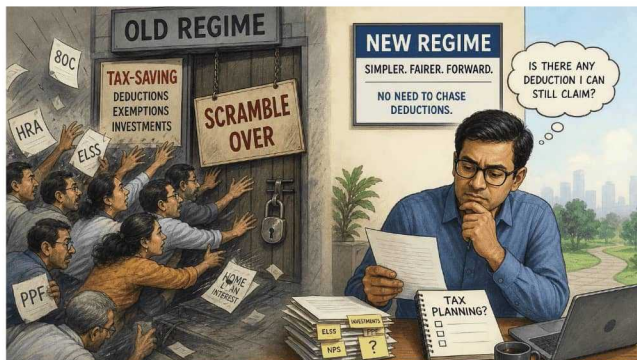
The new regime may have ended the scramble over tax-saving, but the instinct behind it stays among some.



DHIRENDRA KUMAR
CEO, VALUE RESEARCH

MONEY MYSTERIES

An investment must first stand up as an investment, and be a tax-saver only by accident. However, this problem has now solved itself. The new tax regime, now the default and chosen by close to three in four taxpayers, has done away with such deductions. Where there is no Section 80C to chase, there is no reason to go shopping for the bad product in March.



Every few months, a story does the rounds that most of us read with envy and bewilderment. Somebody has bought an apartment in one of those Gurugram towers that the developer insists on naming after flowers—the Arallias, the Camellias, the Magnolias, and now the Dahlias—for a sum with enough zeros to buy a village.

The most recent had one of the country's best-known stock market investors, a name most of you would recognise, paying around ₹120 crore for a single flat. The reaction of the ordinary mortal is to assume there must be a clever tax reason behind it, based on the belief that nobody that rich does anything without first consulting a tax adviser.

Maybe there is one, but my own belief is it has little to do with tax and a great deal to do with the oldest motive: the wish to own something that announces that one has arrived.

Think of what the tax law has on offer here. If you sell shares and pour the proceeds into

a house, part of your capital gain can escape tax, but the maximum that is exempt is ₹10 crore which, against a flat of ₹120 crore, is just a rounding error. The taxman has not been outwitted—the man has just bought a very expensive home, as the wealthy always do.

Tax-saving not the end goal

I'm discussing this because for most of my writing life, the tax mistake that hurt ordinary savers was the opposite. Every February, the same ritual used to play out: a saver who had ignored the matter all year would recall the deadline and, in the last fortnight of March, buy an endowment policy heavy with commission or a five-year deposit paying a whisker above inflation, then console himself that at least he had saved some tax. The point I kept making was that an investment must first stand up as an investment, and be a tax-saver only by accident.

However, this problem has now solved itself. The new tax regime, now the default and

chosen by close to three in four taxpayers, has done away with such deductions. Where there is no Section 80C to chase, there is no reason to go shopping for the bad product in March. The government did not reform anyone's behaviour—it just removed the bait, and that worked just as well.

But the instinct behind all that has not died with the deduction. The willingness to let the tax tail wag the investment dog has merely climbed the wealth ladder to the one tax that still bites—capital gains, whose various shelters survived the new regime untouched. However, they do their real harm not to the Camellia-Dahlia types, but those with a couple of fewer zeros.

There is the man who has done well in equities, holding something liquid and diversified, who is talked into turning the lot into a single illiquid flat because the tax saved feels like money found lying on the road. And there is the one who locks fifty lakh into a government bond paying 5% for five years, every rupee of it taxable, to escape a 12.5% tax he could have paid once and forgotten. In each case, he ends up with the worse asset because the tax tail has wagged the dog again.

The sensible course is the one I have always pressed: give tax its due and nothing beyond it. Ask of any flat or bond or policy whether you would still want it if the tax break vanished overnight. If the answer is yes, buy it and treat the relief as a bonus. If the answer is no, no exemption is worth being saddled with the asset itself. As for the gentleman in the Dahlias, leave him in peace. He has bought a flower-named home with a nice view, which is a very old and very human thing to do, and that's all.

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Rupee sees weekly fall as merchant, NDF-linked flows blunt dollar retreat

The rupee closed modestly higher on Friday but logged a weekly fall as dollar demand related to merchant flows, arbitrage trades and maturities in the non-deliverable forward (NDF) market outweighed comfort from a broadly weaker US dollar.

The domestic unit declined nearly 1% on the week to close at 95.21 per dollar, slipping past the 95 per dollar level for the first time in three weeks.

Improved foreign portfolio inflows into government bonds and expectations of a balance of payments surplus for the year ending March 2027 has improved sentiment on the rupee, even though day-to-day flows continue

to pinch the unit, traders and analysts said.

"USD/INR has been on a rollercoaster ride even before the Iran conflict, driven by a combination of weak capital inflows and also rising foreign direct investment repatriation. Nonetheless, RBI's (Reserve Bank of India's) FX measures have started to stabilise the Indian rupee," MUFG said in a note. The measures include incentives to draw inflows via dollar deposits and overseas borrowings.

ICICI Bank is considering its first dollar bond sale in nearly nine years, after peers HDFC Bank and Axis Bank used the central bank's lower-cost



hedging facility for foreign-currency issuance, Reuters reported earlier in the day.

During the week, dollar demand linked to maturing positions in the NDF market and large merchant payments

pressured the rupee.

"It (USD/INR) is sticking to the trend of following the dollar higher but lagging on the way down," according to a trader at a private bank.

The dollar index was down 0.2% at 100.7 and on course for its biggest weekly loss in 12 weeks on Friday after a tepid investment report from the United States cooled market expectations for a near-term Federal Reserve interest rate hike.

Shares log weekly gain

Meanwhile, in domestic equities, shares rose to log their fourth consecutive weekly gain on Friday, after the softer-than-expected US jobs report coupled

with declining oil prices eased near-term Federal Reserve rate-hike concerns.

The easing came as a relief to the Indian IT sector, a heavyweight on the benchmarks, which has taken a battering of late on AI-disruption fears and prospects of higher rates that typically subdue US client spending.

The benchmark Sensex gained 0.34% to 77,763.91 on Friday, while the Nifty 50 rose 0.39% to 24,270.85. The Sensex and Nifty rose about 0.9% this week, extending their four-week gains to 4.7% and 3.9%, helped by lower oil and steps to support both the rupee and foreign inflows.

—Reuters

I would like to congratulate and thank the *ET Wealth* editor and the entire team for coming up with the 'Paathshaala' page. I believe this is a valuable addition to the weekly. Beginning the series with UPI was an excellent idea. Quite often, we see children enthusiastically snatching their parents' phones in marketplaces to make digital payments. While there is usually no harm because parents supervise them initially, after a few such instances, parents often become less attentive. That is when payment apps can be mishandled or misused, even unintentionally. I hope Paathshaala continues as a regular feature and covers many more topics related to children and teenagers, e.g. the concept of savings, the role of banks, etc.

Amit Singh Khokhar

This is in reference to the column 'Money lessons for young adults'. I belong to a school of thought which discourages giving pocket money to students. Parents may get their sons or daughters things they really need, but desist from giving money to them. However, at the same time, parents

Easing compliance

The cover story on taxation relating to foreign assets, investments and income is admirably comprehensive. Income tax return (ITR) filing in cases of foreign exposure is quite complicated and a common taxpayer is not fully conversant with retrieving relevant information from tax portals, such as the Annual Information Statement (AIS), Tax Identification Number (TIN), and Form 26AS as well as compliance to reporting in relevant schedules. Non-compliance and incomplete disclosure entail penalties and scrutiny. So, it is desirable that the taxman provide pre-filled ITRs to taxpayers having foreign income, transactions, remittances and investments to ensure full and true disclosure.

Vinod Johri

should make their grown-up children realise that it is very hard to earn money. This will indeed make them grow responsibly in the modern society.

S. Ramakrishnasaye



Apropos to the story 'Market's going public,' the NSE IPO is a landmark event in India's capital market history, but retail investors must temper enthusiasm with clear-eyed analy-

sis. A business deriving 77% of transaction revenue from options alone is structurally exposed to regulatory risk. Sebi has already tightened F&O rules; further restrictions are possible. NSE is a quality franchise—dominant, profitable, with a high-growth index licensing segment. But it's not a defensive investment. Long-term investors who understand exchange economics will find merit here. Short-term traders chasing listing gains are walking into the very volatility NSE's own risk systems are designed to curb.

Abbharna Barathi

The figure of ₹8,973 crore lying unclaimed with life and general insurers as highlighted in the story 'Unclaimed insurance money: Is some of it yours?' is both staggering and avoidable. The root causes are familiar: absent nominees, outdated contact details, and policyholders who never informed their families. Bima Bharosa portal is a useful initiative, but discoverability alone solves only part of the problem. Insurers must be mandated to send annual policy summaries to registered mobile numbers and emails, regardless of whether a claim is pending.

S. Durga Arunkumar

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Homebuyers, check these documents

If you are confused by personal finance terms, jargon and calculations, here's a series to simplify and deconstruct these for you. In the 110th part of this series, **Riju Mehta** lists the legal certificates that are crucial for home ownership.

Property is one of the most expensive acquisitions for most people. As such, it's important to conduct due diligence to ensure it's free from disputes, financial liabilities or fraudulent title claims. This can be done by securing, examining and verifying the following documents carefully during the purchase process.

Sale deed

This crucial document proves that the ownership of the property has been legally transferred from the seller to the buyer. It's important to register it at the sub-registrar's office after the sale with correct and accurate details.

Mother deed

This document provides the history of property ownership and traces its transfer over the years. It helps confirm that the property changed hands legally without any disputes or frauds.

Encumbrance certificate

This certificate shows whether the property has any financial or legal liabilities

in a specified period. It's important that you check it for a long duration of around 30 years to ensure the property has no encumbrances.

Completion certificate

This is issued by the local authority certifying that the property has been built and completed in accordance with the approved plan and building regulations. It is issued after the building has been constructed.

Occupancy certificate

This document is issued by the local municipal authority certifying that the property has been constructed in compliance with the building bye-laws and sanctioned plan, and that it is safe and fit for occupation.

Allotment letter

This is issued by the builder, developer, or housing authority to confirm that the property has been allotted to the buyer, usually at the booking stage. It acts as proof that a specific unit has been allot-



ted to the buyer for a given price.

Possession letter

This document is issued by the builder or developer, informing the buyer that the property is ready for physical possession after completion.

Mutation letter

This document, issued by the local municipal authority or revenue department, updates the legal transfer of property in government records. It registers the name

of the new owner, which helps in the correct owner paying the property tax.

No-objection certificate

It's important to have NOCs from various local authorities such as the water board, electricity department, fire department, etc., confirming compliance with the regulatory requirements and ensuring the safety and proper functioning of these utilities.

RERA registration certificate

This certificate proves that the project has been registered with the state's real estate regulator under the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016 (RERA), and can be legally marketed and sold, helping avoid any frauds or mis-selling of the property.

Tax receipts

The receipts help confirm that the taxes have been paid by the previous owner so that the new owner does not have to bear the financial liability of the overdue taxes and penalty.

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Our panel of experts will answer questions related to any aspect of personal finance.

I'm a single parent and my only son is now a foreign national. I want to safeguard his interests and am wondering should I make him a co-owner of my properties—to reduce his paperwork, regarding inheritance? – Jamshed

Properties comprise both movable assets, such as bank accounts, investments, jewellery and vehicles, and immovable assets, such as land, houses and apartments. Upon your demise, your ownership—whether partial or complete—in these assets will need to be legally transmitted to your legal heirs or beneficiaries through the applicable succession process.

Since your son is a foreign national, adding his name as a joint owner in your assets during your lifetime would generally be treated as an exempt gift under Indian tax laws.

However, you should also evaluate the tax implications in your son's country of residence or domicile, as the transfer may attract gift, inheritance or reporting obligations under local laws. In the case of immovable property, adding him as a co-owner would also require payment of the applicable stamp duty and registration charges, making it important to weigh the costs and benefits before proceeding.



Rajat Dutta
Founder & Initiator,
Inheritance Needs Services

I applied for travel insurance for my upcoming Europe trip but I didn't get any help regarding network hospitals. How do I ensure that I have such lists before I travel? –Reeta Madan

For travel insurance, overseas hospital support works differently from domestic health insurance. Insurers typically do not provide a fixed or a pre-defined list of affiliated hospitals before travel, as medical assistance abroad is usually managed through international assistance partners. For Europe trips, most insurers work with global assistance providers that help coordinate medical care and facilitate cashless hospitalisation. In practice, travellers are generally guided to an appropriate nearby hospital based on the situation, location, and medical requirement. The key to a smooth claim experience is early intimation. In case of a medical emergency, one must inform the insurer, broker or both at the earliest to help coordinate treatment and support cashless arrangements where possible. Before travel, it is useful to save emergency contact details and understand the claims, exclusions and assistance process. The reassuring part is that travel insurance follows a streamlined process and helps travellers access medical care abroad with ease.



Sarbvir Singh
Joint Group CEO, PB Fintech

When I am nearing retirement, should I stick to monthly income streams from bank FDs or move to an SWP after making a lump sum investment? – Krishna Sarker

The decision between sticking to bank FDs/debt mutual funds or moving to a systematic withdrawal plan (SWP) in equity/hybrid mutual funds comes down to a classic trade-off between guaranteed income vs tax efficiency and growth. Rather than choosing just one, a combination of both provides the ultimate balance of safety and inflation protection. An effective retirement blueprint uses both tools complementarily by following the bucket strategy. For this you will need to prepare two investment buckets 1. Immediate income bucket; and 2. Growth income bucket. In bucket 1, put a portion of your retirement lump sum into safe instruments like bank FDs and debt mutual funds and use this to secure your monthly expenses. In bucket 2, invest the remaining larger portion into moderate risk hybrid mutual funds or equity savings mutual funds and let this grow untouched for the first 3 years after which you can start an SWP.



Rushabh Desai
Founder, Rupee With Rushabh
Investment Services

Please send your queries to etwealth@timesofindia.com, mentioning your full name and city of residence.



Prism SIF

Provided by **Jio BlackRock**

Prism Hybrid Long-Short Fund

Data driven. Risk-first. Outcome oriented.

NFO: 29th June 2026 - 13th July 2026

Consult your Mutual Fund Distributor or RIA to know more or visit: www.jioblackrockamc.com/prismsif

Invest via Regular or Direct plans.



Prism Hybrid Long-Short Fund

(An interval investment strategy investing in equity and debt securities, including limited short exposure in equity and debt through derivatives)

This product is suitable for investors who are seeking*:

- Long - term capital appreciation with income generation
- An Interval investment strategy investing predominantly in equity and debt securities, including limited short exposure in equity and debt through derivatives

Investors should consult their financial advisers if in doubt about whether the product is suitable for them.

The above product labelling assigned during the New Fund Offer (NFO) is based on an internal assessment of the characteristics of the investment strategy or model portfolio and the same may vary post NFO when the actual investments are made.



*The Risk Band shall be as specified by AMFI.

Investments in Specialized Investment Fund involves relatively higher risk including potential loss of capital, liquidity risk and market volatility. Please read all investment strategy related documents carefully before making the investment decision.